

# The Periphery Strikes Back

Democratic Breakdown through Civic Organizations  
in Interwar Japan

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**ABSTRACT.** Parties and the military are democracy’s two gatekeepers: when both exclude radicals, democracy should survive. Interwar Japan defies this expectation. Established parties controlled parliament and the mainstream military contained its radical faction, yet democracy collapsed. I show that radicals circumvented both gates through civic organizations that built organizational infrastructure for political violence, culminating in the February 1936 coup. Using monthly data on 4,000 right-wing organizations, I find that the May 1932 assassination of the prime minister triggered a sharp organizational surge in Japan’s northern periphery—a region excluded from the governing coalition, where anti-centralist nationalism resonated. Two years of severe depression produced no differential mobilization. The surge concentrated among organizations aligned with the Imperial Way faction, whose members went on to participate in political violence at sharply elevated rates. Periphery-linked personnel bridged disconnected clusters across the radical-right ecosystem. Institutional gatekeepers alone cannot secure democracy against organized radical mobilization from outside.

## 1. INTRODUCTION

Democratic breakdown follows two pathways (Svolik 2014): parties bring radicals into government, or the military seizes power. Each pathway has a gatekeeper. Parties exclude radicals from legislative power (Bermeo 2016; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2019); the military hierarchy contains its own radical faction (Geddes 1999; Powell 2012). When both gates hold, the conventional pathways to breakdown are closed.

This paper shows that radicals locked out of both institutions can still damage democracy by organizing outside them. Interwar Japan held both gates—and democracy collapsed anyway. Two established parties retained firm control of parliament, without the conservative fragmentation (Bermeo 2016) or socialist threat (Acemoglu et al. 2022)

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that opened the door for fascists in Germany and Italy. The military was divided, but the moderate mainstream blocked the radical faction's pathway: when radicals attempted coups, the mainstream refused to rally and the plots collapsed (Kitaoka 2021, pp. 117–120; Shillony 1973). Neither institutional channel was breached from below, yet democracy fell.

Locked out of both formal paths, radical officers and agrarian nationalist ideologues turned to civic organizations that operated through two channels. The *mobilization channel* built the organizational base from which political violence drew participants: organizations propagating *Shōwa Restoration*—a program of party dissolution, direct imperial rule, and national reconstruction that the February 1936 rebels invoked. The *coordination channel* linked radical officers across army divisions and sustained violence outside the chain of command. Individual acts of violence could shock but not sustain; only durable organizations could propagate ideology to communities and link conspirators serving in different garrisons. The perpetrators of the May 1932 assassination circulated through these organizations; the same periphery-linked personnel later bridged otherwise disconnected clusters in the February 1936 coup conspiracy. After the coup, the army formalized an absolute veto over cabinet formation, ending party governance.

This strategy took root in Japan's northern periphery, a "left behind" region (Rodríguez-Pose 2018; Royer and Leibert 2024) whose feudal domains lost the 1868 civil war and were excluded from the governing coalition. That defeat left durable anti-centralist grievance, making local communities receptive to movements framing national politics as exploitation by the center. The May 1932 assassination of the prime minister—by radical officers and agrarian nationalists who explicitly named the northeast as the region most victimized (Chūseidō 1934, pp. 8–13; Shillony 1973)—aligned radical rhetoric with this pre-existing identity. The perpetrators' agrarian-nationalist motives were public before press censorship was imposed the following day, and a preceding cascade of political violence had already primed the interpretive context (Snow et al. 1986). Peripheral grievance and anti-centralist identity were preexisting; what the assassination supplied was a frame that activated them.

Drawing on a monthly prefecture-level panel of over 4,000 right-wing organizations, I find that grassroots organizational density increased sharply in the periphery after the assassination, while two years of severe depression produced no differential mobilization. The event-study estimates are flat throughout the pre-period—including through the Manchurian Incident of September 1931—and rise discontinuously at the May 1932 assassination. Organizational density in the northern periphery nearly doubled within twelve months. The mobilization was ideologically specific: a triple-difference shows that the surge concentrated disproportionately among organizations espousing anti-democratic doctrine—party dissolution and direct imperial rule—aligned with the Imperial Way faction (*Kōdōha*). An organization-level DiD shows that Imperial Way organizations were 8.3 percentage points more likely to have violence-linked members after the Blood Pledge League assassinations of early 1932—a 2.2-fold increase from a pre-treatment base of 3.7%. The surge built the recruitment base from which the radical movement drew its violence, not merely its rhetoric. A network analysis of the full radical-right ecosystem—19,000 persons and 4,000 organizations—shows that periphery-linked individuals held disproportionate brokerage positions (permutation  $p = 0.008$ ), with the mobilization and coordination channels occupying structurally separate network positions.<sup>[2]</sup>

These findings make three contributions. First, the paper identifies a pathway to democratic breakdown that operates entirely outside formal institutions and succeeds even when both gatekeepers hold. Anti-democratic civic mobilization is a recognized precursor to authoritarian transitions (Hellmeier and Bernhard 2023), but the European cases that anchor the comparative literature involved fascist movements colonizing preexisting civic networks (Berman 1997; Satyanath, Voigtländer, and Voth 2017). Japan’s radicals lacked that option: state-directed associations monopolized rural organizational life (Smethurst 2019), leaving no existing networks to colonize and forcing radicals into what Paxton (1966) calls *rooting*—building new organizations from scratch. Existing democratic erosion frameworks center on incumbents who exploit their office (Bernhard

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<sup>[2]</sup>This paper focuses on the earlier stages of radicalization before the critical institutional erosion of the late 1930s. For the later phase, in which US economic sanctions drove legislative elites toward authoritarian alignment through material vulnerability rather than ideological conviction, see Fukumoto (2026).

2020) or opposition elites competing through formal channels (Bennett and Livingston 2025); Japan’s case falls outside both. The mechanism is not colonization of civil society but construction of it.

Second, the paper provides temporal leverage on the center-periphery cleavage (Lipset and Rokkan 1967) that existing cross-sectional designs cannot. Peripheral status is increasingly recognized as a driver of radical-right support (Rodríguez-Pose 2018; Royer and Leibert 2024; Ziblatt, Hilbig, and Bischof 2024), but peripherality correlates with poverty and sectoral decline (Acemoglu et al. 2022; Colantone and Stanig 2018), making the two difficult to separate. Two years of severe depression produced no differential mobilization in the northern periphery, but a single political assassination framed in anti-centralist terms triggered an immediate organizational surge—distinguishing the political-identity dimension from the economic one within the same region and time period.

Third, this temporal variation reveals a supply-demand structure in radical mobilization. Demand—agrarian grievance and an anti-centralist identity rooted in the region’s exclusion from the governing coalition—was present throughout the depression but produced no organizational response. What changed in May 1932 was the supply side: the assassination amplified a dormant interpretive frame (Snow et al. 1986), diagnosing peripheral hardship as central-government exploitation and prescribing collective action. Political entrepreneurs can activate grievance when they supply a frame that matches a pre-existing cleavage (Correa, Nandong, and Shadmehr 2025; Rabushka and Shepsle 1972; Vries and Hobolt 2020), but the activation is geographically specific: the frame resonated only where the political-historical exclusion gave anti-centralist nationalism local salience (Bueno De Mesquita 2010). This distinguishes the mechanism from accounts in which grievance shocks produce mobilization uniformly.

## 2. MOBILIZATION OF THE PERIPHERY

### 2.1. Treatment: May 15 Incident

The May 15 assassination reveals how radical ideology traveled from its creators to communities that had never encountered its authors. On May 15, 1932, young naval officers, army cadets, and civilian agrarian nationalists assassinated Prime Minister Inukai Tsuyoshi and attacked the Metropolitan Police headquarters and the Bank of Japan (Shillony 1973; Siniawer 2008). The conspirators drew on the agrarian nationalism of Gondō Seikyō (from Fukuoka) and Tachibana Kōzaburō (based in Ibaraki), framing rural hardship as betrayal by a central government that exploited agriculture to fuel industrialization (Havens 1974, pp. 163–178). Neither ideologue was from the northern periphery, yet the movement took root there rather than in Fukuoka or Ibaraki—what mattered was not proximity to the ideologues but whether the local population already possessed the identity the ideology addressed. Their rallying cry was *Shōwa Restoration*, the slogan that would define the Imperial Way faction and animate the February 26 rebels four years later (Siniawer 2008, pp. 133–134).

The assassination was designed to ignite mass mobilization, not to seize power. The conspirators’ manifesto called on “farmers, workers, and all the people” to rise (Shillony 1973, p. 21), and the perpetrators named the northeast (*Tōhoku*) as the region most victimized by central-government policy in their court martial testimony (Chūseidō 1934, pp. 8–13). The military refused to rally and the coup collapsed, but the event did not need to succeed as a coup to function as a focal shock. A cascade of radical violence—the Hamaguchi shooting (November 1930), foiled coups in 1931, and the Blood Pledge League assassinations of February–March 1932 (Kitaoka 2021, pp. 178–179)—had already linked agrarian grievance to anti-establishment terrorism in public consciousness. Press censorship was imposed the following day (Kishino 1995, pp. 18–19), but the assassination and the agrarian-nationalist identity of the perpetrators were public before censorship took effect, and the preceding violence had established the interpretive frame through which the event was understood. The mobilization response accumulated over months and years

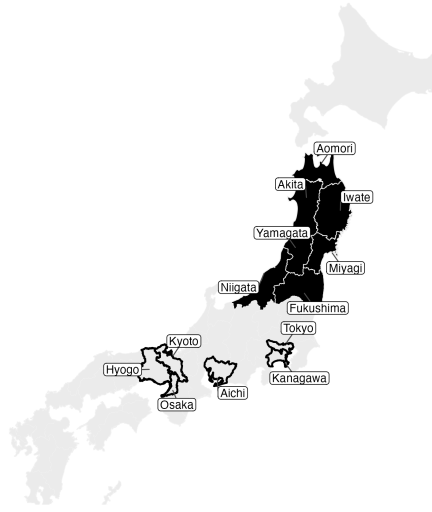


Figure 1: Northern Periphery

**Note:** Filled: northern periphery (Aomori, Iwate, Miyagi, Akita, Yamagata, Fukushima, Niigata). Bordered: metropolitan (Tokyo, Osaka, Kanagawa, Kyoto, Aichi, Hyogo).

(as the event study confirms), consistent with diffusion through organizational networks rather than a reaction requiring immediate access to the perpetrators’ manifesto.

## 2.2. Treatment Group: Northern Periphery

Peripheral status, not geography or poverty, determined where the May 15 shock activated radical mobilization. The perpetrators’ agrarian nationalism (*nōhon-shugi*) circulated throughout Japan’s rice belt (Havens 1974), but it resonated only where communities already possessed an anti-centralist identity that predated the modern state—where peripheral status generated receptiveness to anti-center mobilization (Rodríguez-Pose 2018; Royer and Leibert 2024). The Seiyūkai and Minseitō drew electoral support from rural notables in the northeast but provided little material response to the agrarian crisis (Luebbert 1991), leaving farming communities available for radical mobilization.

The treatment indicator is membership in seven prefectures (Aomori, Iwate, Miyagi, Akita, Yamagata, Fukushima, and Niigata) highlighted in Figure 1. All seven belong to the historic domains of the *Ōuetsu Reppan Dōmei* (Northern Alliance), the coalition of northeastern feudal lords that opposed the Meiji Restoration forces in the Boshin War of 1868. The Alliance was a hastily assembled wartime coalition, not a pre-existing political community: Sendai (Miyagi) was a powerful domain with substantial post-Restoration

agency, while Akita initially fought against the Alliance before being pressured to join. The Meiji state’s response varied in severity—from punitive dissolution of domains like Aizu to more lenient treatment of Akita—but the region as a whole was excluded from the governing coalition and neglected in early statebuilding, creating a shared structural position as peripheral subjects of a government imposed by southwestern victors (Harada and Kubota 2025). That identity persisted into the twentieth century. The May 15 perpetrators explicitly identified the northeast as the locus of central-government exploitation in their court martial testimony (Chūseidō 1934, pp. 8–13), providing a direct basis for treating these prefectures as the region most exposed to the shock’s ideological content.<sup>[3]</sup>

This ideological resonance was not merely rhetorical—it was organizational. The *Mutsu Kokoku Dōshikai* (Mutsu National Revival Comrades’ Association), founded in Aomori in February 1932 with sixty members, illustrates the mechanism: national ideology translated into local organizational form. Its charter combined the standard Imperial Way program—divine restoration, direct imperial rule, Shōwa Restoration—with demands specific to the northeast: rural salvation, northern border defense, and clemency for the Blood League and May 15 defendants. By May 1932, its founders had established a 270-member farmers’ movement arm under the guidance of nationalist writer Nagano Akira, embedding radical ideology in a vehicle that addressed the material grievances of Tohoku’s farming communities. The pattern—national ideologues supplying the doctrinal framework, local organizers adapting it to regional grievance—recurred across the northern periphery.

Other prefectures shared the economic conditions—rice dependence, depression-era hardship—but lacked the structural peripheralization that made agrarian nationalism’s anti-center framing resonate as a diagnosis of their own experience. The northern periphery exhibits all four dimensions of peripheralization (Royer and Leibert 2024): selective out-migration, disconnection from political decision-making, dependency on a central government that directed investment elsewhere, and discursive stigmatization

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<sup>[3]</sup>Niigata is not included in the conventional Tōhoku regional classification but belongs to the Northern Alliance through the Nagaoka domain. Niigata prefecture also included domains that fought on the Meiji government’s side, and the NP coefficient increases from 0.203 to 0.227 when Niigata is dropped, consistent with its mixed allegiance attenuating rather than driving the result (Appendix C.3).

as a backward, defeated region. The treatment is membership in a region defined by this upstream cause—peripheral status—rather than by geography alone or downstream economic structure.

### 2.3. Outcome: Grassroots Right-Wing Organization Density

The data used throughout this paper come from a comprehensive registry of right-wing organizations compiled by Nagata (2014), which records founding and dissolution dates, membership lists, and stated purposes for over 4,000 organizations active between 1868 and 1945. The registry contains both grassroots organizations and those with military officer affiliations; I exploit this distinction throughout, using military-affiliated organizations to trace the coordination channel and grassroots organizations to measure the mobilization channel.

Organizational density—the count of active grassroots right-wing organizations per 100,000 population in a prefecture-month—measures the mobilization channel directly: local actors choosing to organize around radical ideology. The variable excludes government-affiliated bodies (veterans’ associations administered by the Home Ministry, reservist branches, and similar state-sponsored entities) and faction-affiliated organizations. State-directed organizations—the Imperial Military Reservist Association, the Greater Japan Youth Association, and youth training centers—enrolled millions of members through 14,000 branches reaching virtually every hamlet (Smethurst 2019), but they promoted army loyalism and national unity, not the Imperial Way program of party dissolution and direct imperial rule. Excluding them and the officer-affiliated organizations separates grassroots mobilization from both pre-existing state infrastructure and the coordination channel.<sup>[4]</sup> The measure is a stock: it counts every organization whose founding date falls on or before the period and whose dissolution date (if any) falls after it.

Figure 2 plots organizational density for the northern periphery (solid) and other non-metropolitan prefectures (dashed). Both groups rose gradually before May 1932,

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<sup>[4]</sup>The DDD result in Table 2 provides a further distinction: the post-shock surge was disproportionately Imperial Way, a factional specificity that nationally uniform, centrally coordinated state organizations cannot explain.



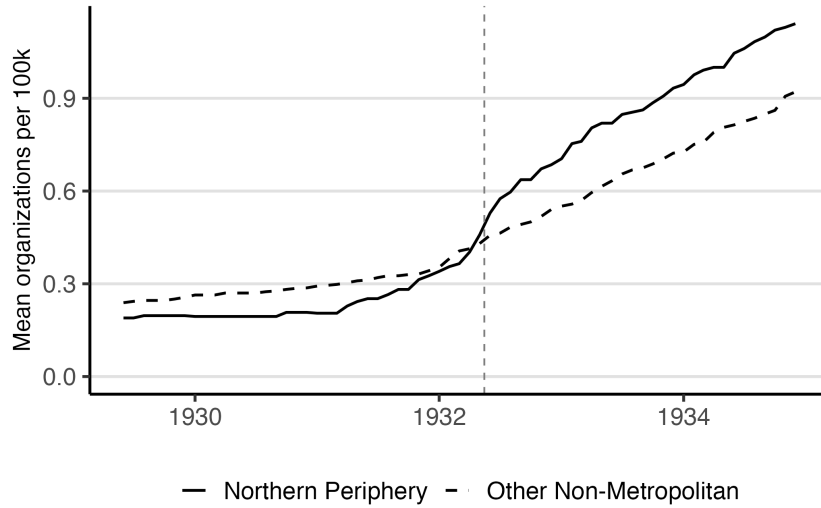


Figure 2: Northern Periphery Diverges After the May 15 Incident

**Note:** Monthly mean of grassroots right-wing organizations per 100,000 population. Solid: northern periphery (all seven treated prefectures); dashed: other non-metropolitan prefectures. Dashed vertical line marks May 1932.

with the northern periphery initially at or below the non-metropolitan average. After the assassination, the periphery’s trajectory steepened, overtaking the comparison group and opening a growing gap through the prewar period. The geographic concentration of this acceleration—in the periphery rather than across all economically distressed areas—together with the change in slope at a political rather than economic shock, points to peripheral status as the operative condition.

The treatment date is not arbitrary. To establish the timing of this divergence without imposing an assumed break point, I apply the structural break methodology of [Bai and Perron \(1998\)](#) and [Bai and Perron \(2003\)](#) to the monthly gap in mean organizational density between northern periphery and other non-metropolitan prefectures. The supremum  $F$  statistic is 266.2 ( $p < 0.001$ ), decisively rejecting the null of no structural break, with the maximum located at May 1932, the incident month itself. A forced single-break model places the estimated break at May 1932 with a 90 percent confidence interval of April–June 1932. The BIC-optimal unrestricted model identifies three breaks (March 1931, May 1932, May 1933), with May 1932 consistently among them, marking it as the dominant structural shift in the series, distinct from earlier Depression-era movements and later organizational consolidation. The March 1931 break likely reflects

a national-level shift—the deepening Depression or the failed March 1931 coup attempt (Kitaoka 2021, p. 119)—that affected NP and non-NP prefectures alike and is therefore absorbed by the month fixed effects in the DD specification. The May 1933 break likely reflects organizational consolidation: the initial post-shock founding surge stabilized while existing organizations persisted in the stock, producing a second inflection in the gap series. The algorithm pins the dominant organizational break at the month of a single political assassination, not at any point during the preceding agrarian depression.

## 2.4. Identification Strategy

The design identifies the composite NP effect—the bundle of traits that distinguish the northern periphery—rather than any single component of peripherality in isolation. The region’s historical peripheralization correlates with economic vulnerability: exclusion from the governing coalition produced the rice dependence, out-migration, and low income that constitute the proximate conditions. With seven treated prefectures that share Boshin War history, climate, crop mix, and distance from Tokyo, separating this political-historical relationship from its economic correlates is the central identification challenge.

The DiD estimates are therefore estimates of this composite. Two features of the evidence, however, provide suggestive leverage on which component within the bundle is doing the most work. First, the correlation between peripherality and economic conditions is imperfect: other rice-growing prefectures shared these proximate conditions but lacked the historical identity and did not develop comparable organizational infrastructure. Farm prices “plunged again by 1931 to only two-fifths their 1919 level” nationwide (Havens 1974, p. 136), yet only in the northeast did a mobilizational response materialize. Second, the temporal pattern is informative: two years of severe agrarian depression produced no differential mobilization in the NP (the event study in Figure 4 is flat throughout the pre-period), but the political shock triggered an immediate divergence. The economic channel predicts a gradual response tracking the depression; a channel operating through the region’s structural relationship to the state predicts a discontinuous response at a political shock framed in anti-centralist terms. The data match the latter.

One might object that economic hardship created the conditions and the assassination merely triggered them, but this cannot explain why other equally distressed prefectures—which experienced the same assassination—did not mobilize. The geographic specificity of the response to a politically framed event points to the identity dimension. The design cannot isolate which dimension of peripheralization—out-migration, political exclusion, economic dependency, or discursive stigmatization—is operative, but the temporal pattern is more parsimonious with an identity or status-based mechanism than with material hardship alone. A subgroup analysis below further probes this question: NP prefectures outside the 8th Division’s jurisdiction—those without radical officer garrisons—also show positive effects, consistent with peripheral identity operating independently of military exposure.

I exploit this variation in a monthly panel of Japan’s 47 prefectures from January 1931 to May 1934, where the pre-period captures the early phase of the global depression prior to the May 15, 1932 assassination. Monthly temporal resolution, rare in studies of interwar radicalization, permits precise identification of responses to discrete political events rather than slower-moving economic or institutional trends. I measure five downstream economic conditions at the prefecture level: economic shock (change in per-capita income, 1929–1931), rice dependence (rice production value / gross prefectural product, 1925 base), per-capita income in 1931, sharecropper rate (pure sharecroppers / total sharecropper-plus-owner-cultivator households, 1931),<sup>[5]</sup> and agriculture dependence (agricultural share of gross value added, 1925). Income data are from the Imperial Statistical Yearbook, agricultural and industrial output from the Hitotsubashi Database on Gross Prefectural Product in Prewar Japan and Ministry of Agriculture and Forestry Statistics.

#### **2.4.1. Difference-in-Differences**

The baseline specification is a difference-in-differences (DD) regression estimated as a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) model:

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<sup>[5]</sup>The Imperial Statistical Yearbook edition of a given year reports data collected during the preceding calendar year; conditions as of 1931 are thus recorded in the 1932 edition.

$$\text{OrgDensity}_{p,t} = \beta \left( \text{NorthernPeriphery}_p \times \mathbb{1}_{\{t > T_0\}} \right) + \mathbf{X}'_p \delta \mathbb{1}_{\{t > T_0\}} + \varphi_p + \psi_t + \varepsilon_{p,t}$$

where  $T_0$  is May 1932. The dependent variable  $\text{OrgDensity}_{p,t}$  is the count of existing grassroots right-wing organizations per 100,000 population in prefecture  $p$  in month  $t$ . The treatment indicator  $\text{NorthernPeriphery}_p$  is a binary variable for prefectures in the northern periphery region, and  $\mathbf{X}_p$  is a vector of pre-treatment covariates—including a metropolitan indicator, economic shock, rice dependence, tenant rate, per-capita income, agriculture dependence, tenant union density, and landowner union density—interacted with the post indicator. All models include prefecture ( $\varphi_p$ ) and month ( $\psi_t$ ) fixed effects, with standard errors clustered by prefecture and month.

A central identifying assumption is parallel trends: absent the shock, the treatment and control groups would have followed the same trajectory. I assess this using an event-study specification that replaces the single post indicator with relative-time indicators around May 1932:

$$\text{OrgDensity}_{p,t} = \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k \left( \text{NorthernPeriphery}_p \times \mathbb{1}_{\{t - T_0 = k\}} \right) + \mathbf{X}'_p \delta \mathbb{1}_{\{t > T_0\}} + \varphi_p + \psi_t + \varepsilon_{p,t}$$

where  $T_0$  is May 1932 (the first post-shock month) and  $\mathbf{X}_p$  includes the same covariates as in the baseline DD. As a further check, [Appendix C.4](#) reports synthetic difference-in-differences (SDD) estimates ([Arkhangelsky et al. 2021](#)), which relax the parallel trends requirement by constructing a data-driven, weighted combination of control units and pre-treatment time periods; results are consistent with the baseline. Geographic spillovers between NP and adjacent control prefectures are possible but would most likely attenuate the estimated treatment effect: if organizations founded in the NP diffuse to adjacent control prefectures, the control group’s organizational density rises, narrowing the gap and biasing the NP coefficient toward zero.

#### 2.4.2. Cardinality Matching

To adjust for the observable economic differences between the northern periphery and control prefectures, I apply cardinality matching ([Zubizarreta, Paredes, and Rosenbaum](#)

2014) on five covariates: rice dependence, economic shock (change in per-capita income, 1929–1931), per-capita income in 1931, agriculture dependence, and sharecropper rate. Cardinality matching finds the largest balanced subset of treated and control units satisfying a pre-specified SMD tolerance on all covariates simultaneously; I set this tolerance to 0.25, the threshold below which remaining bias can be reliably removed by linear regression adjustment (Imbens and Rubin 2015). The TWFE DD model is then re-estimated on this matched sample.

Figure 3 reports standardized mean differences (SMD) before and after matching. All five covariates—which together capture the major economic conditions emphasized in the existing literature on Imperial Way mobilization: the severity of the economic shock, agricultural structure, baseline wealth, agriculture dependence, and tenancy—move within the  $\pm 0.25$  threshold, yielding a balanced sample of 12 prefectures (6 of the 7 treated, 6 control).

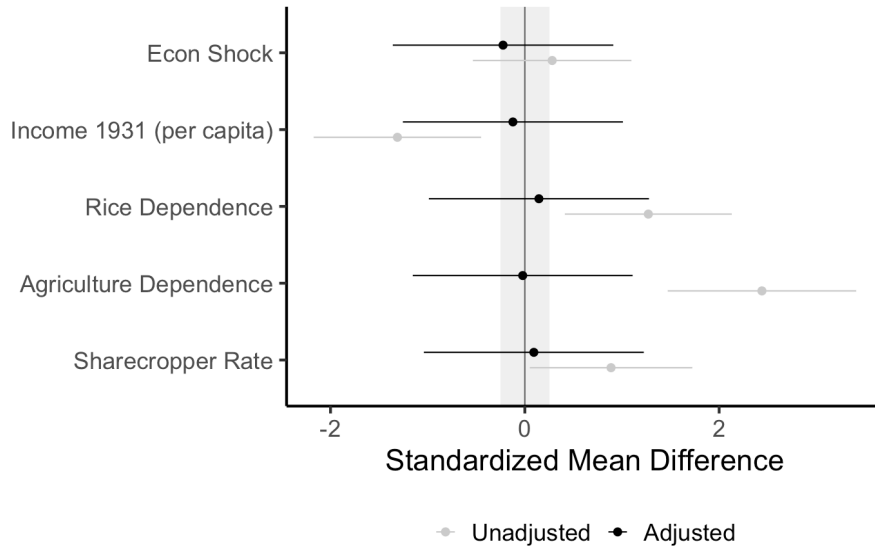


Figure 3: Matching Achieves Covariate Balance

**Note:** Standardized mean differences (SMD) before (gray) and after (black) cardinality matching (SMD tolerance 0.25, 12 matched prefectures), with 95% confidence intervals. Five matched covariates: rice dependence, economic shock (1929–1931), per-capita income (1931), agriculture dependence, and sharecropper rate. Light-gray band marks the  $\pm 0.25$  SMD region within which linear adjustment is considered reliable (Imbens and Rubin 2015).

| Outcome                     | Org Density (per 100k)               |                                      |                                      |                                    |                                      |                                      |                                     |                                     |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
|                             | Standard DD                          |                                      |                                      |                                    | Cardinality Matching DD              |                                      |                                     |                                     |
| Model:                      | (1)                                  | (2)                                  | (3)                                  | (4)                                | (5)                                  | (6)                                  | (7)                                 | (8)                                 |
| Post-Treatment Period:      | +12m                                 | +24m                                 | ~Feb 36                              | ~Jul 37                            | +12m                                 | +24m                                 | ~Feb 36                             | ~Jul 37                             |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP)   | 0.283 [0.208]                        |                                      |                                      |                                    |                                      |                                      |                                     |                                     |
| NP $\times$ Post            | 0.2029<br>(0.0497)***<br>[0.0418]*** | 0.2362<br>(0.0618)***<br>[0.0598]*** | 0.2629<br>(0.0950)***<br>[0.0978]*** | 0.2588<br>(0.1052)**<br>[0.1097]** | 0.2042<br>(0.0309)***<br>[0.0241]*** | 0.2310<br>(0.0409)***<br>[0.0282]*** | 0.2447<br>(0.0838)**<br>[0.0702]*** | 0.2526<br>(0.1028)**<br>[0.0867]*** |
| RI 95% CI                   | [0.076, 0.330]                       | [0.072, 0.410]                       | [0.045, 0.461]                       | [0.011, 0.475]                     | —                                    | —                                    | —                                   | —                                   |
| Controls                    |                                      |                                      |                                      |                                    |                                      |                                      |                                     |                                     |
| Metropolitan $\times$ Post  | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                | No                                   | No                                   | No                                  | No                                  |
| Econ. Profile $\times$ Post | No                                   | No                                   | No                                   | No                                 | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                 | Yes                                 |
| Prefecture FE               | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                 | Yes                                 |
| Month FE                    | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                | Yes                                  | Yes                                  | Yes                                 | Yes                                 |
| Fit Statistics              |                                      |                                      |                                      |                                    |                                      |                                      |                                     |                                     |
| Matched prefectures         | —                                    | —                                    | —                                    | —                                  | 12                                   | 12                                   | 12                                  | 12                                  |
| Observations                | 1,363                                | 1,927                                | 2,914                                | 3,713                              | 348                                  | 492                                  | 744                                 | 948                                 |
| Within $R^2$                | 0.296                                | 0.297                                | 0.281                                | 0.263                              | 0.603                                | 0.507                                | 0.340                               | 0.303                               |

Table 1: Northern Periphery Mobilization Surge Is Robust to Matching

**Note:** Clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors in parentheses; Conley spatial SEs (100 km cutoff) in brackets. Columns 1–4: TWFE DD on all prefectures with Metropolitan  $\times$  Post control. Columns 5–8: matching-adjusted TWFE DD on cardinality-matched non-metropolitan sample (SMD tolerance 0.25; 12 matched prefectures) with the five matching covariates  $\times$  Post; Metropolitan  $\times$  Post is excluded because no metropolitan prefecture enters the matched control group. RI: Randomization inference 95% CI; Fisher exact interval from 1,000 random 7-prefecture placebo groups. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.

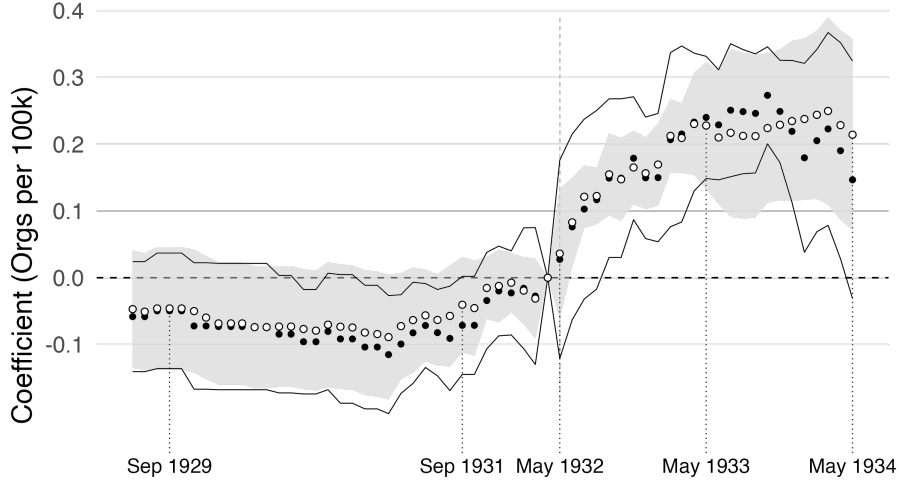


Figure 4: Discontinuous Mobilization Surge in the Northern Periphery

**Note:** Points show coefficient estimates with 95% confidence intervals from the event-study specification. Open circles with gray-shaded CIs: standard DD; black filled circles: cardinality-matched DD (matched on rice dependence, economic shock 1929–1931, per-capita income 1931, agriculture dependence, and sharecropper rate).

## 2.5. Results

[Table 1](#) reports the results. The northern periphery—the region where peripheral status and elite ideology converged—exhibits a sharp mobilization surge; other regions, including those with comparable downstream economic conditions, do not. Columns 1–4 present the baseline DD estimates. Right-wing organizational density in northern periphery prefectures rose by 0.20 per 100,000 population in the 12 months after May 1932 (spatial randomization inference  $p < 0.001$ ), increasing to 0.24 at 24 months and remaining stable through the full prewar window. Relative to the pre-treatment mean (0.283 organizations per 100,000), the 12-month effect represents a gain of approximately 72 percent. In concrete terms, a typical NP prefecture of roughly one million people had two to three grassroots right-wing organizations before the shock; the effect adds approximately two more within a year, nearly doubling the number of organizations. Across all seven NP prefectures, this translates to roughly fourteen additional organizations from a base of twenty—and because the stock measure captures persistence, this infrastructure continued to accumulate: by 36 months, the typical NP prefecture had roughly five grassroots right-wing organizations where it had previously had two to three.

Columns 5–8 assess whether these estimates survive adjustment for economic covariate imbalance via cardinality matching on the non-metropolitan sample only (12 matched prefectures). The matched specification includes the five matching covariates interacted with the post-shock indicator. The northern periphery effect is 0.20 ( $p < 0.001$ ) at 12 months, rising to 0.23 at 24 months and 0.25 over the full prewar window. As a complementary test, [Appendix C.11](#) reports a flow event study using new organization foundings per quarter per 100,000 as the outcome. The flow confirms the post-shock timing but with noisier pre-treatment coefficients, reflecting the sparseness of quarterly founding events; the stock measure is the preferred specification because it captures the operative organizational infrastructure at each point in time rather than the one-time event of founding.

The event-study results in [Figure 4](#) show no evidence of systematic pre-trends, supporting the parallel trends assumption. Organizational density in the northern periphery remains flat in the pre-period despite severe agrarian strain: rice prices had

collapsed from 1930 and per-capita incomes had fallen sharply by 1931. A joint  $F$ -test for the 15 pre-treatment coefficients fails to reject the null of zero pre-trends in both the standard DD ( $F(15, \cdot) = 0.456$ ,  $p = 0.962$ ) and the matching DD ( $F(15, \cdot) = 0.343$ ,  $p = 0.991$ ); extending the pre-period to June 1929 (34 coefficients) yields even more emphatic nulls ( $p = 0.990$  and  $p > 0.999$ ). Consistent with the identification argument above, this flatness extends specifically through the Manchurian Incident period (September 1931 onward)—the more transformative *national* political shock of the early 1930s produced no differential mobilization in the northern periphery. A formal placebo test with September 1931 as the treatment date confirms this: the NP coefficient over the following eight months is 0.05 ( $p = 0.125$ ), less than a quarter of the May 1932 effect ([Appendix C.2](#)). The Manchurian Incident was a consensus event that generated near-universal public enthusiasm across regional cleavages; the May 15 assassination was an ideologically contested act whose perpetrators explicitly framed their cause in anti-centralist agrarian terms. The ideological content of the shock, not its national severity, drove the differential organizational response.

The abrupt surge is specific to the northern periphery. Metropolitan areas also show positive and statistically significant TWFE coefficients ([Table A.14](#)), but the corresponding event study ([Appendix C.10](#)) reveals monotonically increasing pre-treatment trends and gradual post-shock growth without any discontinuity at the shock, indicating that the May 1932 event did not produce comparable mobilization in those prefectures.

## 2.6. Alternative Explanations

The NP effect could reflect economic deprivation or local connections to the perpetrators rather than peripheral identity. I consider each in turn.

To test the economic channel, I replace the northern periphery with placebo treatment groups: the top 7 non-metropolitan prefectures by each of five economic covariates and a composite of all five  $z$ -scores ([Appendix B](#)). Because NP prefectures appear in several placebo groups (3–4 out of 7), the tests are biased *in favor* of finding significant effects. All five individual placebo tests yield statistically insignificant coefficients at the



+12-month window, despite this conservative overlap (Figure A.10). The 5-covariate composite is marginally significant but substantially smaller than the main NP estimate.

A perpetrator hometown placebo—assigning treatment to the home prefectures of the May 15 conspirators—likewise produces null results, ruling out the possibility that personal networks radiating from the assassins’ places of origin drove the surge. Neither downstream economic conditions nor local ties to the perpetrators can reproduce the northern periphery’s mobilization response.

## 2.7. Robustness Checks

With seven treated prefectures, cluster-robust variance estimators face known small-sample limitations (Conley and Taber 2011; Ferman and Pinto 2019). I therefore supplement cluster-robust inference with randomization inference—permuting the NP label across 1,000 random 7-prefecture groups—which does not rely on asymptotic approximations. The resulting 95% confidence intervals, reported in Table 1, exclude zero at all four post-treatment windows (Appendix C.1). Temporal placebos at May 1931 and May 1933 produce near-zero coefficients (Appendix C.2), and leave-one-out analysis confirms no single prefecture drives the result (Appendix C.3).

Alternative estimators converge on the baseline. The doubly robust DD (Sant’Anna and Zhao 2020) ( $ATT = 0.18$ ,  $p < 0.05$ ; Appendix C.6), synthetic DiD (Arkhangelsky et al. 2021) ( $ATT = 0.14$ ,  $p < 0.01$ ; Appendix C.4), and FEct (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024) ( $ATT = 0.15$ ,  $p < 0.05$ , placebo  $p = 0.70$ ; Appendix C.7) all confirm a sharp post-shock surge. Extended cardinality matching with seven covariates—including tenant and landowner union density—yields an NP coefficient of 0.18 ( $p < 0.01$ ) at the +12-month window, attenuating at longer horizons as the small matched sample limits precision (Appendix C.5). A wild cluster bootstrap (MacKinnon and Webb 2018) rejects the null at the 5% level across all four post-treatment windows (Appendix C). Replacing organization counts with total reported membership (log-transformed) as the outcome yields a coefficient of 0.99 log points ( $p = 0.029$ ), corresponding to a 170% increase in membership density, which strengthens to 1.26 log points ( $p < 0.001$ ) after cardinality matching (Appendix C.9). Appendix C.8 reports sensitivity analysis under the (Rambachan and

Roth 2023) framework for honest confidence intervals; with 7 treated clusters, the framework is extremely conservative and the breakdown value is zero. The identification rests instead on three pieces of evidence that do not depend on this framework: flat pre-trends during two years of severe depression, the FEct out-of-sample equivalence test ( $p = 0.70$ ; Appendix C.7), and the randomization inference confidence intervals reported in Table 1.

### 3. ORGANIZATIONAL EVOLUTION

#### 3.1. Ideology Propagation

The post-shock organizational surge was ideologically specific, not just larger: the region became dominated by organizations whose charters called for ending parliamentary governance—party dissolution, direct imperial rule, *Shōwa Restoration*, state reconstruction—the program historians identify with Imperial Way (*Kōdōha*) doctrine. The classification captures this ideological content rather than factional subordination to the Kōdōha officer clique. The Kōdōha–Tōseiha boundary was more fluid than the labels suggest, and the young officers’ movement was driven partly by academy-class cohorts and career resentment, not solely by ideological adherence to a coherent faction (Kitaoka 2021, pp. 180–181). What matters for democratic erosion is that these organizations’ founding charters called for ending parliamentary governance, regardless of their precise relationship to the military faction—the same program that the February 26 rebels invoked (Kitaoka 2021; Shillony 1973).

Maintaining the restriction to grassroots organizations, I classify each organization’s *rhetorical alignment with radical autocratic goals* using keywords from its stated purpose, background, or ideology: *kōdō* (Imperial Way), *Shōwa ishin* (Shōwa Restoration), *seitō kaishō* (party dissolution), *tennō shinsei* (direct imperial rule), and *kokka kaizō* (state reconstruction).

Figure 5 shows the compositional shift. Panel (a): before the shock, the northern periphery’s Imperial Way share was below 10%, well under the roughly 15% baseline elsewhere. After May 1932, the share rose to 30–40%, overtaking the rest of the country.

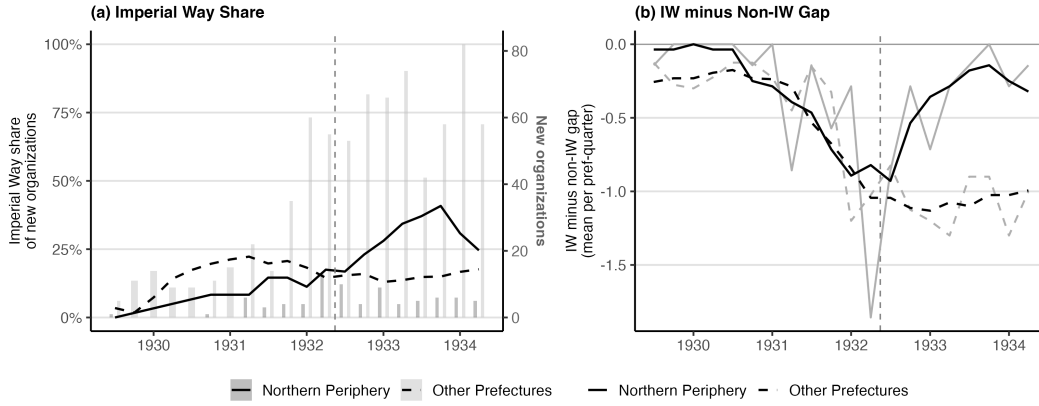


Figure 5: The Peripheral Surge Was Disproportionately Imperial Way

**Note:** (a) Imperial Way share of newly founded grassroots right-wing organizations (lines, left axis); bars (right axis) show total new organizations by region. (b) IW-minus-non-IW founding gap (mean per prefecture), which is the quantity that identifies the DDD. Lines show four-quarter centered moving averages; [Figure A.25](#) in the appendix plots panel (b) at raw quarterly frequency matching the regression data. Solid: northern periphery; dashed: all other prefectures. Dashed vertical line marks May 15, 1932.

The northern periphery did not simply gain more right-wing organizations; it gained a different organizational composition. Panel (b) plots the IW-minus-non-IW founding gap, which is the quantity that identifies the DDD. Before the shock, the gap trends in parallel across the northern periphery and other prefectures; after the shock, the northern periphery's gap rises sharply.

### 3.1.1. Triple-Difference Design

The DDD tests whether the post-shock organizational surge in the northern periphery concentrated disproportionately among Imperial Way organizations, using non-Imperial Way organizations within the same prefecture as an internal comparison group ([Gruber 1994](#)). The outcome is the count of newly founded organizations (flow) at the prefecture-quarter-type level.<sup>[6]</sup>

<sup>[6]</sup>The DDD asks whether *newly created* organizations were disproportionately Imperial Way—a question about the composition of the flow, not the stock. Ideology is classified at founding from the organization's stated purpose, so the stock measure would dilute the post-shock compositional shift with pre-existing organizations whose type was determined years earlier; [Appendix G](#) confirms the result holds, attenuated, with the stock measure. The flow of new foundings is in turn sparse—the pre-treatment NP mean is 0.011 Imperial Way organizations per prefecture-quarter, essentially all zeros—so monthly frequency would leave insufficient variation for the three-way interaction. Quarterly aggregation is the minimal temporal coarsening that yields enough non-zero cells while retaining the resolution to distinguish pre- and post-shock periods.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{NewOrgs}_{p,t,k} = & \beta_1(\text{NP}_p \times \text{Post}_t \times \text{IW}_k) + \beta_2(\text{NP}_p \times \text{Post}_t) \\ & + \beta_3(\text{Post}_t \times \text{IW}_k) + \alpha_{p,k} + \gamma_{t,k} + \varepsilon_{p,t,k} \end{aligned}$$

where  $\text{NewOrgs}_{p,t,k}$  is the count of organizations of type  $k \in \{0, 1\}$  founded in prefecture  $p$  during quarter  $t$ ;  $\text{IW}_k$  indicates Imperial Way type;  $\alpha_{p,k}$  are prefecture-by-type fixed effects absorbing time-invariant differences in the baseline level of each type across prefectures; and  $\gamma_{t,k}$  are quarter-by-type fixed effects absorbing national trends in each type. The coefficient  $\beta_1$  captures whether the NP post-shock surge concentrated disproportionately among Imperial Way organizations.

The identifying assumption is that the *gap* between Imperial Way and non-Imperial Way founding rates would have trended in parallel across NP and non-NP prefectures absent the shock. This requirement is weaker than the standard DD assumption: NP and non-NP prefectures may differ in both IW and non-IW levels and trends, so long as the differential between the two types trends in parallel. A linear pre-trend test on the event-study DDD coefficients yields a slope of 0.0005 ( $p = 0.886$ ): no differential pre-trend. Because any factor that affects both types equally—economic conditions, mobilization capacity, administrative capacity for registration—is differenced out by the within-prefecture type comparison, the specification requires neither economic controls nor population normalization. Standard errors are two-way clustered by prefecture and quarter.

### 3.1.2. DDD Results

Table 2 reports the DDD results. The coefficient ( $\beta_1$ ) is positive and significant from the +24-month horizon onward, confirming that the post-shock surge concentrated disproportionately among Imperial Way organizations. Before the shock, NP prefectures averaged 0.011 Imperial Way organizations founded per quarter—essentially all zeros—so the DDD captures an extensive-margin shift from nonexistence to regular presence.<sup>[7]</sup> The prewar estimate of 0.48 implies that the shock increased Imperial Way founding in NP by

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<sup>[7]</sup>In raw counts: 4 Imperial Way organizations were founded in NP prefectures before May 1932, compared to 26 after (through July 1937). The Imperial Way share of all grassroots foundings in the NP rose from 9.8% to 27.1%, while the corresponding share in non-NP, non-metropolitan prefectures rose more modestly from 5.4% to 14.3%.

| Outcome                                                   | NewOrgs (prefecture $\times$ quarter $\times$ type) |               |          |          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------|----------|----------|
| Model:                                                    | (1)                                                 | (2)           | (3)      | (4)      |
| Post-Treatment Window:                                    | +12m                                                | +24m          | ~Feb 36  | ~Jul 37  |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP, IW)                             |                                                     | 0.011 [0.105] |          |          |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP, non-IW)                         |                                                     | 0.203 [0.601] |          |          |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post <math>\times</math> IW</b> | 0.485*                                              | 0.638**       | 0.617*** | 0.483*** |
|                                                           | (0.280)                                             | (0.255)       | (0.217)  | (0.163)  |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post</b>                        | -0.484                                              | -0.573*       | -0.571** | -0.435** |
|                                                           | (0.349)                                             | (0.309)       | (0.278)  | (0.194)  |
| <i>Controls</i>                                           |                                                     |               |          |          |
| Prefecture $\times$ Type FE                               | Yes                                                 | Yes           | Yes      | Yes      |
| Quarter $\times$ Type FE                                  | Yes                                                 | Yes           | Yes      | Yes      |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>                                     |                                                     |               |          |          |
| Observations                                              | 2,820                                               | 3,196         | 3,572    | 4,418    |
| $R^2$                                                     | 0.530                                               | 0.551         | 0.574    | 0.585    |
| Within $R^2$                                              | 0.003                                               | 0.006         | 0.006    | 0.005    |

Table 2: DDD: NP Surge Is Disproportionately Imperial Way

**Note:** Unit of analysis: prefecture  $\times$  quarter  $\times$  organization type (Imperial Way or non-Imperial Way). Outcome: NewOrgs, count of newly founded grassroots right-wing organizations.  $\beta_1$ : DDD coefficient (NP  $\times$  Post  $\times$  Imperial Way type).  $\beta_2$ : NP  $\times$  Post effect on non-Imperial Way organizations (base category). Clustered (prefecture & quarter) standard errors in parentheses. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

roughly 0.48 organizations per prefecture-quarter relative to the change in non-Imperial Way founding. The base effect ( $\beta_2 = -0.44$ ) shows that non-Imperial Way founding in NP declined relative to other prefectures, even as total organizational density increased sharply. This is consistent with Imperial Way ideology absorbing organizational energy that might otherwise have produced generic nationalist groups: the shock redirected the region's organizational impulse toward the radical program.

Where virtually no Imperial Way organizations had existed, they now predominated. This compositional shift is a direct measure of democratic erosion: the Imperial Way keywords (party dissolution, direct imperial rule, Shōwa Restoration, state reconstruction) constitute the core demands of the movement that staged the February 26 coup. What the northern periphery gained was organizations whose founding charters called for ending parliamentary governance.

Randomization inference confirms the result: one-sided  $p = 0.030$  at +24 months, strengthening to  $p < 0.001$  at the prewar endpoint (Appendix H). Whether these organizations were deliberately planted by Kōdōha officers or spontaneously adopted the

faction’s rhetoric cannot be determined from the keyword data alone. Both pathways are consistent with the bypass mechanism: even planted organizations operated as civic associations outside the military hierarchy. The subgroup analysis favors the grassroots interpretation—prefectures outside the 8th Division’s jurisdiction also show positive effects—but distinguishing the two pathways definitively would require organizational-level evidence on founders’ identities.

Excluding the most ambiguous keyword (*kokka kaizō*) leaves the DDD estimates virtually unchanged (Appendix F). A cross-validation against the personnel-based faction classification (Table A.22, Table A.24) confirms discriminant validity: keyword-classified organizations are significantly more likely to have Kōdōha-affiliated personnel than Tōseiha-affiliated personnel (Fisher  $p < 0.001$ , odds ratio 3.0), though the overlap is limited in the grassroots subsample because the two methods classify different organizational strata by design.<sup>[8]</sup>

### 3.2. Network Ecosystem Isolation

The DDD identifies the compositional shift in the *flow* of newly founded organizations. The full organizational ecosystem reveals the structural character of the infrastructure the shock built. The Nagata registry contains 19,319 persons linked to 3,920 organizations by 30,232 membership edges. I project this bipartite network onto an organization–organization graph: two organizations share an edge if at least one person belongs to both. For each month from 1929 to mid-1937, I identify the set of active organizations (founded and not yet dissolved) and compute *org degree*—the number of other active organizations sharing at least one member—which captures how embedded an organization is in the broader ecosystem.

Figure 6 documents the structural disconnection. Panel (a): NP organizations maintained an org degree near zero throughout the period—their members belonged to no

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<sup>[8]</sup>I validate the keyword set using a chi-squared keyness analysis and leave-one-out cross-validation: removing each keyword from the classification and testing whether it remains statistically over-represented among organizations identified by the remaining keywords. All retained keywords pass this test, confirming internal coherence. The classification is conservative: organizations with nationalist but non-radical-autocratic orientations (e.g., veterans’ associations, shrine-based groups) are coded as non-Imperial Way.

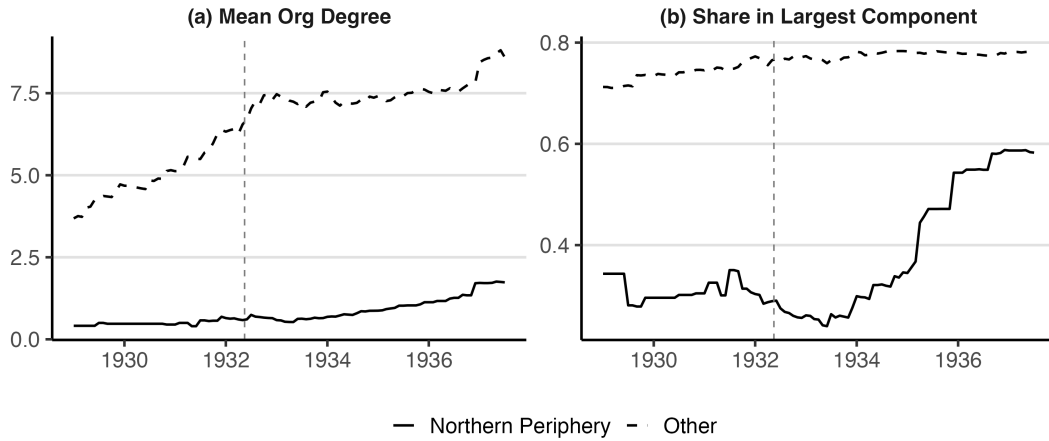


Figure 6: NP Organizations Were Structurally Disconnected from the Broader Network

**Note:** (a) Monthly mean org degree—number of other active organizations sharing at least one member—for NP-headquartered organizations (solid) versus all others (dashed). (b) Share of active persons appearing in the largest connected component (LCC) of the bipartite person–organization network (19,319 persons, 3,920 organizations, 30,232 membership edges; the LCC contains 82.6% of all persons and 59.9% of all organizations). Dashed vertical line marks May 1932.

other organizations, leaving them structurally disconnected from the broader radical-right ecosystem. Non-NP organizations, by contrast, were densely interconnected: their mean org degree rose from roughly 4 to 9 as the network expanded, reflecting a hub-and-spoke structure centered on Tokyo-based organizations whose members held overlapping affiliations. Panel (b): only 30% of NP-linked persons appeared in the largest connected component, compared with 75% of non-NP persons. The gap persists throughout the observation window. NP organizations were grassroots cells whose members were not joining organizations outside the northern periphery. The shock built a parallel infrastructure—many small, locally rooted organizations that grew alongside rather than integrated with the broader ecosystem.

The question is whether this organizational infrastructure merely propagated doctrine or produced violent action. It did the latter.

#### 4. VIOLENCE PRODUCTION

The downstream political stakes become clearest in the movement’s violence. On February 26, 1936, Imperial Way officers led fourteen hundred troops in seizing central Tokyo and murdering Finance Minister Takahashi, Lord Keeper of the Privy Seal Saitō, and

Inspector General Watanabe (Shillony 1973; Siniawer 2008). The coup failed militarily but marked the decisive shift to military autocracy. War Minister Terauchi Hisaichi made reinstatement of the active-duty military minister requirement a condition of army cooperation with the incoming Hirota cabinet. The stated rationale was to bar reserve officers implicated in the revolt—above all Araki Sadao and Mazaki Jinzaburō—from returning to the war ministry; the practical effect was the opposite: it formalized the army’s power to block any cabinet by refusing to nominate a war minister, giving the army an absolute veto over cabinet formation.<sup>[9]</sup> The murder of Takahashi and Saitō eliminated the officials best positioned to resist military encroachment (Kitaoka 2021; Young 2024). The evidence in this section is descriptive rather than causal: it traces how the organizational infrastructure documented above fed violent action and conspiracy brokerage.

#### 4.1. Organizations Produced Violence Participants

Violence participants were deeply embedded in the organizational field. Matching participants in 23 violent episodes—assassinations, coup plots, and armed campaigns between 1931 and 1943—to the organizational network (Nagata 2014), violence participants belonged to 8.4 organizations on average, versus 1.5 for non-participants ( $p < 0.001$ ; Fisher odds ratio for multi- vs. single-organization membership: 15.7,  $p < 10^{-35}$ ). This embeddedness was ideologically specific: Imperial Way organizations differentially gained violence-linked members after the onset of the radical violence campaign.

I construct an organization  $\times$  event panel covering 22 violent episodes—assassinations, coup plots, and armed campaigns between 1930 and 1941—and 3,008 organizations (32,738 organization-event observations). For each episode, I identify all organizations active at the event date and check whether any member participated. The outcome is event-specific: it equals one only if a member was directly involved in that particular episode, avoiding the mechanical persistence of cumulative measures. The specification is:

$$\text{Participant}_{o,e} = \beta IW_o + \gamma_p + \delta_e + \varepsilon_{o,e}$$

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<sup>[9]</sup>The army used this lever to prevent Ugaki Kazushige from forming a government in 1937 (Kitaoka 2021, pp. 191–195).



where  $\text{Participant}_{o,e}$  indicates whether organization  $o$  has a member involved in episode  $e$ ,  $\text{IW}_o$  is the Imperial Way classification,  $\gamma_p$  are prefecture fixed effects, and  $\delta_e$  are event fixed effects. Standard errors are two-way clustered by organization and event.

Table 3 reports the results. Pooling across all events, Imperial Way organizations are 0.85 percentage points more likely to have a member involved in any given violent episode ( $p = 0.020$ ), from a non-IW base rate of 0.62%—a  $2.4\times$  increase. The coefficient is stable across expanding windows that progressively include later events. An interaction with a linear time trend yields an insignificant slope ( $p = 0.31$ ), indicating that the IW–violence premium is a persistent feature of the organizational field, not an artifact of any particular temporal break. Figure 7 plots the IW coefficient from separate cross-sectional regressions at each episode. The IW differential is concentrated in the core episodes of the radical campaign—the Blood Pledge League assassinations ( $p = 0.016$ ), and the October incident, kikansetsu, and shinpeitai conspiracies—and is indistinguishable from zero for events with few or no IW-linked participants.

Violent episodes also shared organizational infrastructure: cross-event person pairs connected by shared organizational membership are especially dense among the March and October incidents, the Blood Pledge League and May 15, and the later Shinpeitai-

| Outcome               | Event Participant (org $\times$ event) |                      |                      |                    |                      |                      |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|--------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
| Model:                | (1)                                    | (2)                  | (3)                  | (4)                | (5)                  | (6)                  |
| Events through:       | ~May 32                                | ~Feb 36              | ~Jul 37              | ~May 32            | ~Feb 36              | ~Jul 37              |
| Mean (IW)             |                                        |                      |                      | 0.016              |                      |                      |
| Mean (non-IW)         |                                        |                      |                      | 0.006              |                      |                      |
| <b>IW</b>             | 0.0218*<br>(0.0116)                    | 0.0138**<br>(0.0058) | 0.0138**<br>(0.0058) | 0.0181<br>(0.0114) | 0.0115**<br>(0.0053) | 0.0115**<br>(0.0053) |
| <i>Fixed Effects</i>  |                                        |                      |                      |                    |                      |                      |
| Prefecture FE         | No                                     | No                   | No                   | Yes                | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Event FE              | Yes                                    | Yes                  | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i> |                                        |                      |                      |                    |                      |                      |
| Organizations         |                                        |                      |                      | 3,008              |                      |                      |
| Events                | 9                                      | 17                   | 17                   | 9                  | 17                   | 17                   |
| Observations          | 6,248                                  | 18,030               | 18,030               | 6,248              | 18,030               | 18,030               |
| $R^2$                 | 0.017                                  | 0.016                | 0.016                | 0.025              | 0.023                | 0.023                |

Table 3: Imperial Way Organizations Disproportionately Supplied Violence Participants

**Note:** Unit of analysis: organization  $\times$  event. Outcome: indicator equal to one if any member of the organization participated in that specific violent episode. IW: Imperial Way classification by founding-charter keywords. Columns 1–3 include event fixed effects only; columns 4–6 add prefecture fixed effects. Two-way clustered (organization & event) standard errors in parentheses. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

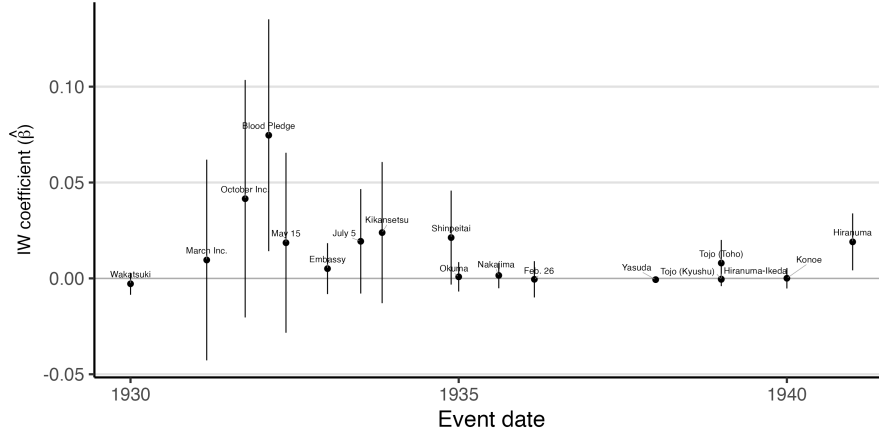


Figure 7: Event-by-Event IW Participation Premium

**Note:** Each point is the IW coefficient from a separate cross-sectional regression of event participation on IW status with prefecture fixed effects, estimated on the subset of organizations active at that episode’s date. Bars show 95% confidence intervals (HC1). Events with zero participants in both groups are omitted. The IW premium concentrates in the core episodes of the radical violence campaign (1931–1934).

centered violence. Successive episodes of radical violence were drawn from a common associational ecosystem, not isolated eruptions.

#### 4.2. NP-Linked Personnel Organized the Feb. 26 Conspiracy

Periphery-linked individuals held the central bridging positions in the February 26 conspiracy network. This coordination channel operated through a different organizational stratum from the mobilization and ideology results above: pre-existing officer-centered ties that connected conspirators across divisions. Of the 52 organizations linking conspirators in the pre-coup network, 36 (69%) were founded before May 1932; the top NP brokers’ centrality derives overwhelmingly from these pre-shock ties. The May 1932 shock did not create these officer networks. It created the broader grassroots infrastructure within which the movement endured. The analysis in this subsection is descriptive—it documents NP-linked persons’ structural centrality in the observed network, not that the conspiracy could not have formed without them.<sup>[10]</sup>

<sup>[10]</sup>The organizational membership data come from the Nagata (2014) registry—a comprehensive directory compiled from Special Higher Police surveillance records and organizational self-reports—not from the February 26 court-martial files. The registry is therefore independent of prosecution decisions, mitigating the concern that differential investigation depth could inflate NP-connected persons’ documented ties.

The military hierarchy alone could not have connected the conspirators. Those with identifiable postings spanned at least five army divisions—the 1st (Tokyo), 6th (Kumamoto), 8th (Hirosaki), 19th (colonial Korea), and Imperial Guard—plus naval officers and dismissed civilians. Officers in different divisions shared no barracks, training cycle, or chain of command; a captain in the 8th Division and a lieutenant in the 6th were over 1,500 km apart with no institutional reason to interact. Academy-class ties linked some officers, but the conspiracy’s reach across five divisions, the navy, and civilians required organizational affiliations beyond military cohort connections. Right-wing civic organizations provided that infrastructure. Using membership lists in the Nagata registry, I reconstruct a bipartite person–organization network linking the February 26 conspirators to the organizations they belonged to before the coup. I define “NP-linked” as persons connected to the northern periphery through birth or military posting—the channels through which individuals gained firsthand experience of agrarian devastation and peripheral grievance.

The 8th Division, headquartered in Hirosaki (Aomori), was the primary radicalization site and the source of the conspiracy’s organizational brokers. Its jurisdiction covered four of the seven NP prefectures (Aomori, Iwate, Akita, Yamagata), and it supplied the largest contingent of February 26 suspects: 5 of 29 officers investigated, more than any other division (Kitaoka 2021, p. 180; Shillony 1973). The physical rebellion was operationally Tokyo-centered, with approximately 1,400 troops mobilized from the 1st Division and Imperial Guard (Shillony 1973, p. 11), but the ideological groundwork was laid in the northeast. Officers stationed there commanded conscripts from Tohoku’s most impoverished farming families; letters from home laid bare the region’s agrarian devastation (Havens 1974; Young 2024, p. 126), grounding their radicalism in firsthand witness rather than abstract doctrine. Kita Ikki, from Niigata, authored the rebels’ manifesto and linked otherwise separate clusters through his membership in the Tenkentō, Yūzonsha, and Kyōchisha. Ogishi Yoriyoshi, posted to the 5th Regiment in Aomori, was designated the movement’s Tohoku regional leader (Shillony 1973, pp. 7–8). Shibukawa Zensuke, from Fukushima, bridged the officer conspiracy to civilian networks across Akita and Yamagata. Suematsu Tahei, also stationed at the 5th Regiment, planned to convert the

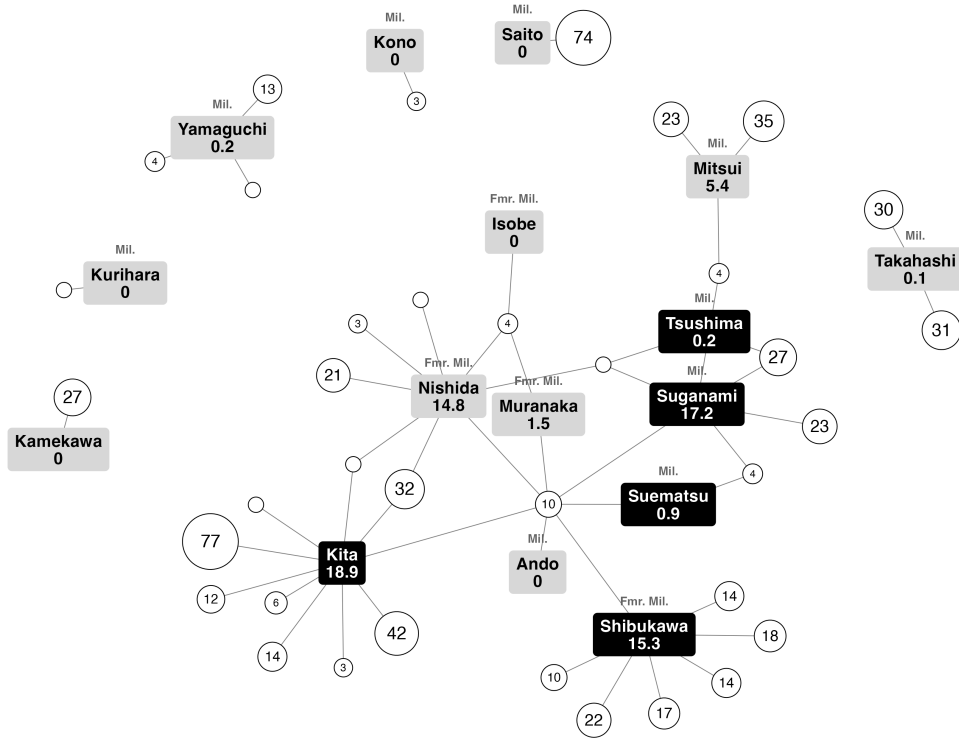


Figure 8: NP Personnel Bridged the February 26 Conspiracy Network

**Note:** Bipartite network restricted to persons tried for the February 26 coup (Table A.22) and the right-wing organizations they belonged to (organizations founded before February 1936). Black fill: NP-connected persons; gray fill: other personnel; *Mil.*: active military; *Fmr. Mil.*: former military (dismissed or retired before the coup). Circles: right-wing organizations in which at least one tried person held membership; circle size is proportional to the organization's total membership count, shown inside each circle (blank if membership data unavailable). An edge connects a person to each organization they belonged to; two persons who share an organization are indirectly linked through it. Numbers below person names show normalized betweenness centrality [0–100]: the share of all shortest paths between other nodes that pass through a given person, measuring how indispensable that person is as a broker connecting otherwise separate clusters.

prefecture into an independent command center: after Tokyo-based conspirators were arrested in November 1934, regional cells were told to “contact Aomori directly without going through Tokyo.”<sup>[11]</sup> Suganami Saburō, posted to the 8th Division, coordinated between regional cells and the Tokyo conspirators.

Figure 8 shows the organizational network of the 41 persons tried by court-martial for the February 26 coup (Table A.22), linking those with organizational ties to the

<sup>[11]</sup>Suematsu Tahei, *Watakushi no Shōwa-shi: Ni-ni-roku Jiken Ibun* (My Shōwa History: February 26 Incident Untold Stories), pp. 237–238. Suematsu writes: “We won’t merely do subcontracting work for Tokyo (*Tōkyō no shitauke shigoto*)—we’ll hang our own signboard” (*dokuji no noren mo sageyō*).

right-wing organizations they belonged to before the coup. Of the 62 defendants and suspects, 19 appear as named members in at least one organization in the full registry, covering every ideologue and organizer, every key intermediary who connected regional cells to the Tokyo conspirators, and every executed officer with documented pre-existing organizational ties (Table A.22, Table A.23). The network includes the major figures of the coup plot: Kita Ikki, the chief ideologue (executed); Nishida Mitsugi, who coordinated the coup plan (executed); Isobe Asaichi and Muranaka Kōji, who planned the assault (both executed); Captain Andō Teruzo, who led the attack squad that killed Inspector General Watanabe (executed); Lt. Kurihara Yasuhide, who led the assault on the Prime Minister’s residence (executed); and Lt. Tsushima Katsuo, from Aomori and posted at the 5th Regiment of the 8th Division (executed) (Shillony 1973). The defendants absent from the registry are uniformly junior officers with no documented pre-existing organizational ties—foot soldiers of the rebellion, not its architects.

Five NP-connected persons, out of 16 in the pre-coup network, accounted for 70.4% of total betweenness centrality—the share of all shortest paths between other conspirators that passed through a given node. Kita (normalized betweenness 18.9), Suganami (17.2), and Shibukawa (15.3) were the three highest-betweenness nodes, the brokers connecting otherwise separate clusters of the movement.<sup>[12]</sup>

A Gould-Fernandez brokerage decomposition of the person–person co-membership projection reveals *how* NP persons bridged: they served overwhelmingly as outsiders mediating between pairs of non-NP conspirators who lacked a direct organizational link—*consultant* brokerage—at 15.5 times the per-capita rate of non-NP persons (9.3 vs. 0.6 brokerage instances per person). Rather than channeling their own members outward, the periphery connected Tokyo-based conspirators to each other. Burt’s network constraint confirms this irreplaceability: NP persons had lower mean constraint than non-NP

---

<sup>[12]</sup>A permutation test randomly reassigning the NP label to 5 of 16 persons 10,000 times yields  $p = 0.016$ , rejecting the null that this concentration arose by chance. This concentration is driven primarily by persons *from* the NP rather than those *posted* there: birth-NP persons (Kita, Shibukawa, Tsushima) account for 68.4% of all NP-connected betweenness and 37.8% of total network betweenness, compared to 31.6% and 17.5% for posting-NP persons (Suganami, Ogishi, Suematsu). Even setting all posting-NP betweenness to zero, birth-NP persons would still account for 45.8% of the remaining network’s brokerage, mitigating the concern that NP centrality reflects military personnel decisions rather than regional network ties.

persons (0.341 vs. 0.495), indicating they spanned structural holes with few alternative paths. Shared organizational membership was what held the conspiracy together.

The brokerage pattern extends to the full radical-right ecosystem—in a network of 19,319 persons and 3,920 organizations, NP persons held 1.82 times expected betweenness (permutation  $p = 0.008$ )—but the aggregate overrepresentation is less informative than its decomposition. Cross-regional bridge persons—those with both NP and non-NP organizational ties—held 2.23 times expected betweenness ( $p = 0.004$ ), while exclusive-NP grassroots members held just 0.12 times expected betweenness; 97.7% of grassroots NP persons did not appear in the largest connected component at all.<sup>[13]</sup> The full-network decomposition therefore reproduces the paper’s core asymmetry: mobilization was local and durable, whereas coordination depended on a small bridge layer. NP-linked persons were overrepresented among pre-coup violence participants (conditional logit odds ratio 2.42,  $p = 0.004$ ), but this overrepresentation disappeared after the February 26 purge of Imperial Way officers. The coordination channel was tied to specific personnel; the Imperial Way organizational infrastructure outlived them.

## 5. CONCLUSION

Formal institutional gatekeeping monitors two channels: party exclusion of radicals and military containment of unauthorized seizure. Japan’s interwar collapse shows that civic organizations can circumvent both. Radicals locked out of both institutions built organizations in the northern periphery that propagated anti-democratic ideology, produced violence participants, and connected otherwise isolated conspirators, constructing the organizational base and coordination networks for the February 1936 coup. That peripheral status—not economic hardship—determined where this infrastructure took root distinguishes the mechanism from grievance-driven accounts: depression-era suffering was national, but the organizational response concentrated where historical exclusion from the governing coalition made anti-centralist nationalism resonate. The May 1932

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<sup>[13]</sup>The mobilization channel was entirely civilian: a DiD on military membership in NP-headquartered organizations finds no differential change ( $p = 0.42$ ). But NP persons gained indirect military exposure at the ecosystem level by joining Tokyo-headquartered organizations that also included military officers ( $p < 0.001$ ).

assassination activated this latent identity where two years of severe depression had not. Once built, the organizational infrastructure exhibited persistence (Hannan and Freeman 1993), intensifying through the end of the prewar period (Figure 4). Democratic resilience requires monitoring not only who enters formal institutions but what is being built outside them.

The two channels had different lifespans. The mobilization channel—the Imperial Way organizational infrastructure—was durable: it continued generating violence participants for a decade, including after the February 26 purge eliminated the officer clique that had coordinated the coup. The coordination channel was event-specific: NP-linked persons were overrepresented among pre-coup violence participants but not post-coup ones. The organizational infrastructure outlived the conspiracy; purging conspirators did not dismantle the base that produced them.

The bypass mechanism takes different forms. Romania’s Legion of the Archangel Michael built grassroots infrastructure in rural communities where the state’s reach was incomplete (Cârstocea 2017), organizational rooting outside functioning institutions, as in Japan. Hungary’s Fidesz captured civic associations from within the party system, converting associational life into a partisan resource (Jakli, Greskovits, and Wittenberg 2025), organizational colonization from inside. Both used civic organizations as the vehicle, through opposite mechanisms, and both succeeded. The common thread is that civic organizations can serve as a pathway to democratic erosion (Hellmeier and Bernhard 2023) that institutional gatekeeping alone cannot prevent. Where durable exclusion from the governing coalition has produced anti-centralist grievance, radical entrepreneurs can activate latent identity when a politically framed event matches the community’s self-understanding—and the window for institutional response may be narrow.

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## APPENDIX

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## A. DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS

|                                    | <i>Full Sample</i> |        |       |        |       | <i>Group Means</i> |        |        |
|------------------------------------|--------------------|--------|-------|--------|-------|--------------------|--------|--------|
|                                    | <i>N</i>           | Mean   | SD    | Min    | Max   | NP                 | Other  | Metro  |
| <i>Panel A: Outcome</i>            |                    |        |       |        |       |                    |        |        |
| Org. density (per 100k)            | 47                 | 0.051  | 0.068 | 0.000  | 0.435 | 0.029              | 0.038  | 0.151  |
| <i>Panel B: Covariates</i>         |                    |        |       |        |       |                    |        |        |
| Rice share of GVA                  | 47                 | 0.160  | 0.077 | 0.005  | 0.328 | 0.237              | 0.164  | 0.049  |
| Economic shock (p.c.)              | 47                 | −0.004 | 0.003 | −0.019 | 0.003 | −0.004             | −0.004 | −0.005 |
| Sharecropper rate                  | 47                 | 0.460  | 0.115 | 0.136  | 0.699 | 0.537              | 0.439  | 0.489  |
| Per-capita income 1931             | 47                 | 0.040  | 0.036 | 0.007  | 0.208 | 0.024              | 0.030  | 0.116  |
| Agriculture dependence             | 47                 | 0.289  | 0.098 | 0.035  | 0.446 | 0.379              | 0.303  | 0.104  |
| Tenant union rate                  | 47                 | 0.200  | 0.180 | 0.000  | 0.893 | 0.146              | 0.214  | 0.182  |
| Owner union rate                   | 47                 | 0.281  | 0.767 | 0.000  | 3.491 | 0.024              | 0.066  | 1.797  |
| Population density                 | 47                 | 199.7  | 200.0 | 14.8   | 1,086 | 83.5               | 161.9  | 549.8  |
| Road density (km/km <sup>2</sup> ) | 47                 | 3.50   | 2.22  | 0.48   | 10.8  | 1.76               | 3.52   | 5.40   |

Table A.4: NP Prefectures Are More Rural and Less Organized Before Treatment

**Note:** Prefecture-level pre-treatment statistics for all 47 prefectures. *N* is the count of prefectures with non-missing values; no variable has missing observations. Outcome averaged over pre-treatment months (Jan 1931–Apr 1932). Group means: NP = northern periphery (*N* = 7); Other = non-metropolitan, non-NP (*N* = 34); Metro = metropolitan (*N* = 6). Economic shock: mean per-capita income change 1929–1931 (thousands of yen). Per-capita income 1931 in thousands of yen. Rice share: rice production value divided by gross prefectural product (1925). Tenant household share and union organization rates at 1932. Road density in km per km<sup>2</sup> (1932). *Sources:* Right-wing organizations from Nagata (2014); rice share and agriculture dependence from Hitotsubashi GPP Database and MAFF Statistics; all other variables from the Imperial Statistical Yearbook (*Teikoku Tōkei Nenkan*).

## B. PLACEBO TESTS

Figure A.9 shows the two placebo prefecture groups. For each economic covariate, I rank non-metropolitan prefectures and select the top 7 as a placebo treatment group, matching the NP size; a 5-covariate composite ranks by the sum of all  $z$ -scores. The perpetrator hometown group collects the home prefectures of the May 15 conspirators.

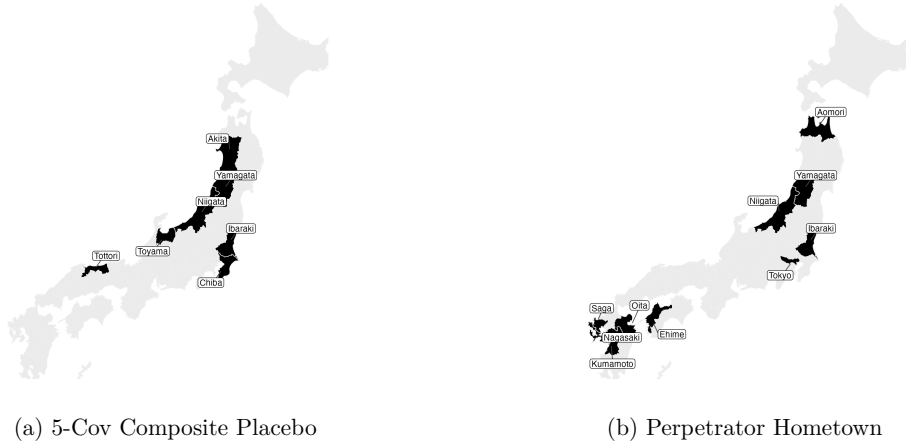


Figure A.9: Placebo Prefecture Groups

**Note:** (a) Top 7 non-metropolitan prefectures by composite  $z$ -score (rice dependence + economic shock + income + agriculture dependence + sharecropper rate): Akita, Ibaraki, Yamagata, Chiba, Toyama, Niigata, Tottori (4 overlap with NP). (b) Perpetrator hometown prefectures: Saga, Nagasaki, Niigata, Aomori, Oita, Ehime, Kumamoto, Ibaraki, Yamagata, Tokyo (3 overlap with NP).

Figure A.10 reports the placebo coefficient estimates. All individual and composite placebo tests yield statistically insignificant or substantially smaller coefficients than the NP main effect, despite the conservative overlap with NP prefectures.



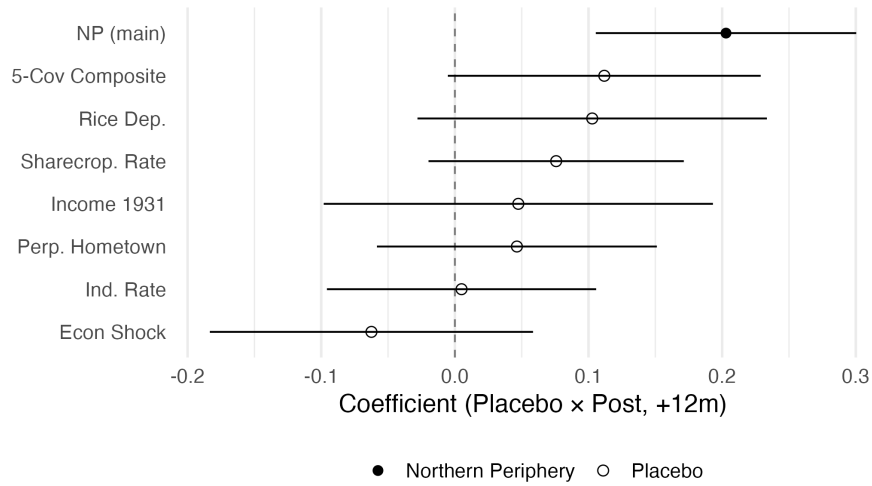


Figure A.10: Neither Economic Conditions nor Perpetrator Proximity Predict Mobilization

**Note:** Shown are point estimates and 95% confidence intervals for the placebo  $\times$  post coefficient at the +12-month window. Each individual placebo selects the top seven non-metropolitan prefectures (including any overlap with NP prefectures) for a given covariate; the 5-covariate composite ranks prefectures by the sum of all five  $z$ -scores. Because NP prefectures may enter both placebo groups and the main estimation, the test is biased toward detecting spurious effects. For comparison, the NP main effect is also displayed. All models include prefecture and month fixed effects, with standard errors clustered by prefecture and month.

## C. ROBUSTNESS

Each robustness check is detailed in the subsections below, with figures presented in their respective sections.

### C.1. Spatial Placebo

| Statistic                                              | Value  | Details                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------------------------------|
| True N. Periphery effect                               | 0.2029 | Post $\times$ Treated coefficient (+12m) |
| <b>Baseline placebo (random)</b>                       |        |                                          |
| Placebo p-value                                        | 0.000  | Two-sided; 1,000 simulations             |
| <b>Matched placebo (rice dependence + econ. shock)</b> |        |                                          |
| Matched p-value                                        | 0.000  | Two-sided; 1,000 matched groups          |

Table A.5: True Effect Lies Far in the Tail of the Placebo Distribution

**Note:** The placebo distribution uses the +12-month post window with metropolitan  $\times$  post control. Baseline placebo uses random 7-prefecture treated groups excluding metropolitan prefectures; matched placebo restricts to the closest groups on rice-dependence and economic-shock moments.

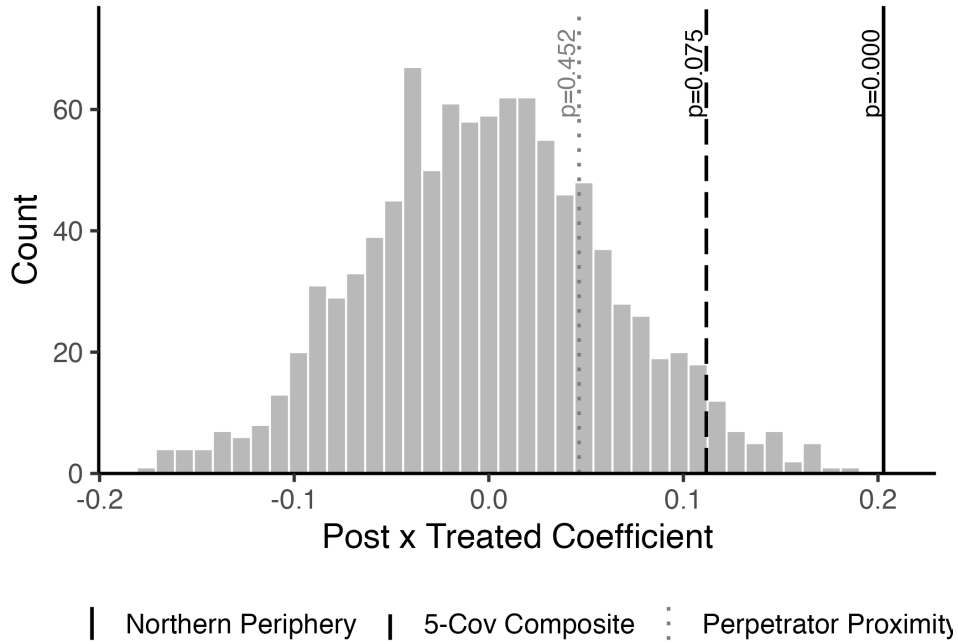


Figure A.11: Spatial Placebo Distribution

**Note:** Placebo DD estimates from 1,000 randomly selected 7-prefecture treated groups (excluding metropolitan prefectures). The true NP estimate (vertical line) lies far in the tail of the distribution ( $p < 0.001$ ).

## C.2. Temporal Placebo

Table A.6 reports the temporal placebo test. I shift the treatment date one year earlier (May 1931) and one year later (May 1933), re-estimating the DD within symmetric  $\pm 12$ -month windows around each placebo date. Both placebo coefficients are substantially smaller than the true May 1932 effect, confirming that the mobilization effect is specific to the May 1932 shock. Figure A.12 shows the corresponding event studies: the May 1931 placebo exhibits no clear break, while the May 1933 placebo shows a flat trajectory around the placebo date.

| Model:                               | (1)                | (2)                   | (3)                |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------|--------------------|
| Treatment Date:                      | May 1931           | May 1932              | May 1933           |
|                                      | (placebo)          | (true)                | (placebo)          |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP)            |                    | 0.283 [0.208]         |                    |
| <b>Northern Periphery<br/>× Post</b> | 0.0500<br>(0.0325) | 0.1927***<br>(0.0441) | 0.0595<br>(0.0491) |
| <i>Controls</i>                      |                    |                       |                    |
| Metropolitan × Post                  | Yes                | Yes                   | Yes                |
| Econ. Profile × Post                 | No                 | No                    | No                 |
| Prefecture FE                        | Yes                | Yes                   | Yes                |
| Month FE                             | Yes                | Yes                   | Yes                |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>                |                    |                       |                    |
| Observations                         | 1,128              | 1,128                 | 1,128              |
| $R^2$                                | 0.984              | 0.969                 | 0.976              |
| Within $R^2$                         | 0.141              | 0.293                 | 0.215              |

Table A.6: Effect Is Specific to May 1932

**Note:** Shifting the treatment date to May 1931 or May 1933 yields coefficients substantially smaller than the true May 1932 effect. Each column estimates a DD with the indicated treatment date and a symmetric  $\pm 12$ -month window. All models include metropolitan × post control. Clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors in parentheses. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.

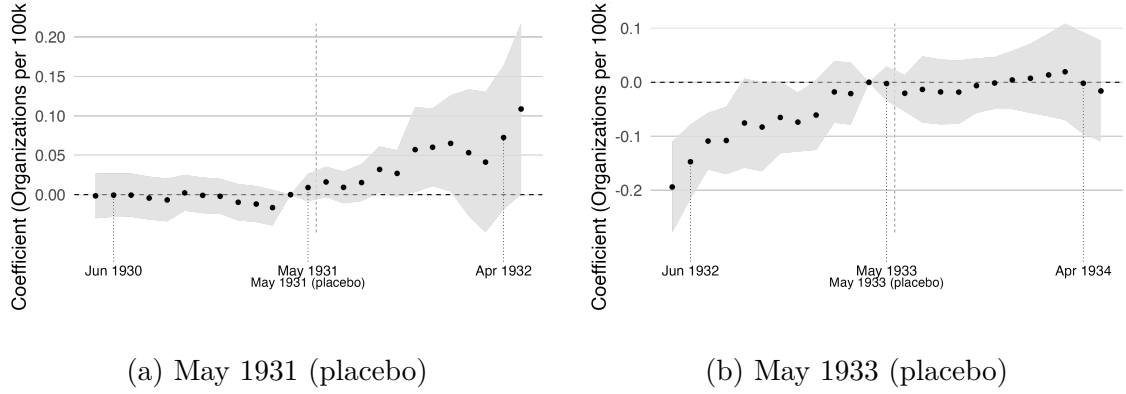


Figure A.12: Temporal Placebo Event Studies Show No Discontinuity

**Note:** Event studies for placebo treatment dates. Panel (a): May 1931 ( $\pm 12$ -month window). Panel (b): May 1933 ( $\pm 12$ -month window). Neither placebo exhibits the sharp post-treatment surge observed at the true May 1932 date (Figure 4).

As a further check, I re-estimate the DD using September 1931 (the Manchurian Incident) as the treatment date, with a +8-month post-window ending in April 1932—the last month before the actual May 15 shock. The NP coefficient is 0.050 ( $p = 0.125$ ), less than a quarter of the May 1932 effect (0.203) and not statistically significant, confirming that the Manchurian Incident—a consensus event generating near-universal enthusiasm rather than factionally specific mobilization—did not produce a differential organizational surge in the periphery.

### C.3. Leave-One-Out

| Excluded Prefecture | N     | Coefficient | SE       |
|---------------------|-------|-------------|----------|
| Aomori              | 1,334 | 0.1765***   | (0.0475) |
| Iwate               | 1,334 | 0.2115***   | (0.0552) |
| Miyagi              | 1,334 | 0.2256***   | (0.0495) |
| Akita               | 1,334 | 0.1892***   | (0.0535) |
| Yamagata            | 1,334 | 0.2053***   | (0.0551) |
| Fukushima           | 1,334 | 0.1855***   | (0.0529) |
| Niigata             | 1,334 | 0.2265***   | (0.0496) |

Table A.7: No Single Prefecture Drives the Result

**Note:** Common pre-period (1931-01-01 to 1932-05-15) and +12-month post window. SE column reports clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors. Each row re-estimates the DD with one northern periphery prefecture omitted.

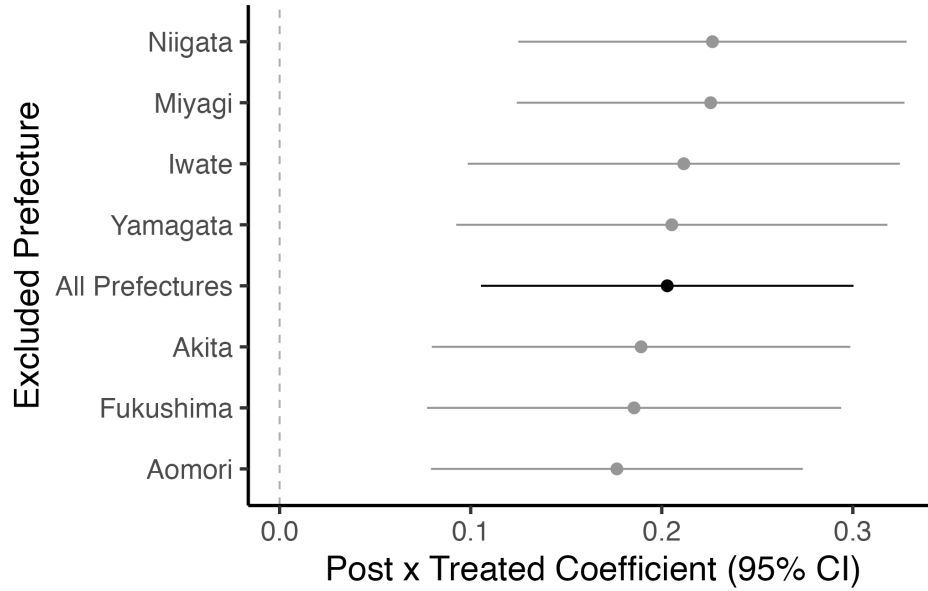


Figure A.13: Leave-One-Out Coefficient Estimates

**Note:** Post  $\times$  Treated coefficient (with 95% CIs) from DD models that omit one northern periphery prefecture at a time. No single prefecture drives the result.

## C.4. Synthetic Difference-in-Differences

Synthetic difference-in-differences (SDD) (Arkhangelsky et al. 2021) relaxes the parallel-trends assumption by constructing weighted controls and time periods to match the northern periphery’s pre-shock path. The donor pool comprises 34 non-metropolitan prefectures. With a +12m post window, the SDD ATT is 0.140 (SE = 0.053,  $p < 0.01$ ), consistent with the baseline DD estimate (0.203, Table 1).

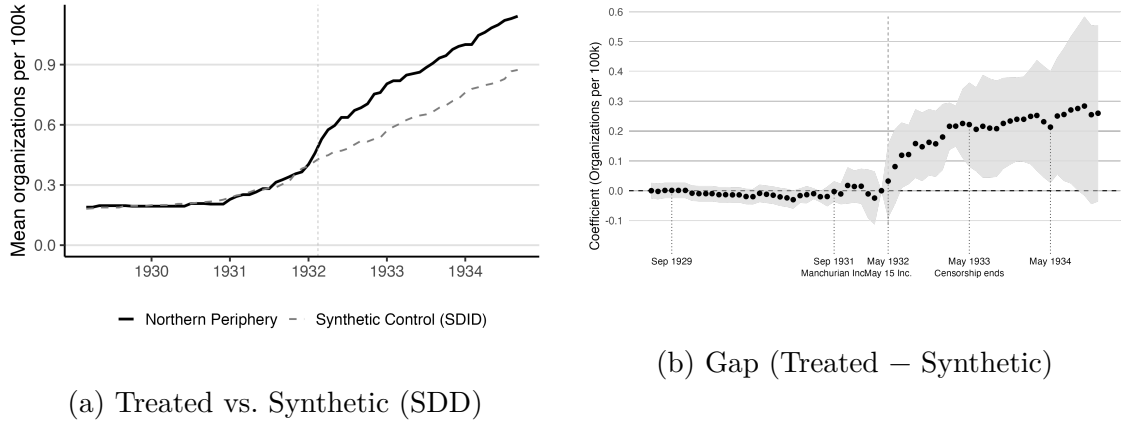


Figure A.14: Synthetic DD Confirms the Post-Shock Peripheral Surge

**Note:** Panel (a): solid line shows the mean organizational density across the 7 northern periphery prefectures; dashed line shows the SDD-weighted synthetic control (intercept-adjusted). Panel (b): the gap between treated and synthetic over time. Dashed vertical line marks May 15, 1932.

Table A.8 reports the SDD ATT across post-treatment windows.

| Model:                    | (1)                   | (2)                   | (3)                 | (4)                 |
|---------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Post-Treatment Period:    | +12m                  | +24m                  | ~Feb 36             | ~Jul 37             |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP) | 0.283 [0.208]         |                       |                     |                     |
| <b>N. Periphery ATT</b>   | 0.1404***<br>(0.0488) | 0.1673***<br>(0.0673) | 0.1895*<br>(0.1062) | 0.1801*<br>(0.1047) |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>     |                       |                       |                     |                     |
| Treated prefectures       | 7                     | 7                     | 7                   | 7                   |
| Control prefectures       | 34                    | 34                    | 34                  | 34                  |
| Pre-treatment periods     | 36                    | 36                    | 36                  | 36                  |
| Post-treatment periods    | 12                    | 24                    | 45                  | 62                  |
| Observations              | 1,968                 | 2,460                 | 3,444               | 4,018               |

Table A.8: Synthetic DD Confirms the Post-Shock Effect

**Note:** SDD ATT across post-treatment windows. Pre-treatment period: June 1929 to May 1932. SDD estimates from the synthdid package (Arkhangelsky et al. 2021). 7 treated (northern periphery) and 34 non-metropolitan control prefectures. Jackknife standard errors in parentheses. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

## C.5. Seven-Covariate Cardinality Matching

Table A.9 reports matching-adjusted DD estimates from cardinality matching on all seven economic covariates (SMD tolerance 0.35), with economic profile covariates interacted with Post. The tolerance is relaxed from 0.25 (used for the five-covariate specification) because seven-dimensional matching on 41 prefectures is more constrained; at 0.35 all seven treated prefectures are retained (versus six at 0.25). The northern periphery coefficient (0.179 at +12 months,  $p < 0.01$ ) tracks the baseline closely. Figure A.15 shows covariate balance before and after matching; every covariate falls within the  $\pm 0.35$  SMD band.

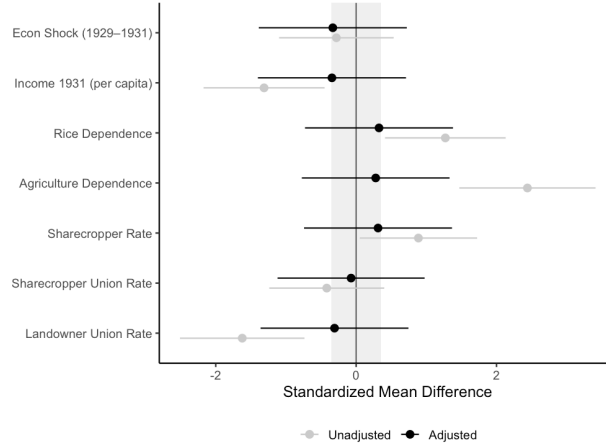


Figure A.15: Seven-Covariate Cardinality Matching Balance

**Note:** Standardized mean differences before (gray) and after (black) cardinality matching on all seven covariates. Light-gray band marks the  $\pm 0.35$  SMD tolerance region.

| <i>7-Cov Cardinality DD</i>                  |                       |                      |                    |                    |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| Model:                                       | (1)                   | (2)                  | (3)                | (4)                |
| Post-Treatment Period:                       | +12m                  | +24m                 | ~Feb 36            | ~Jul 37            |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP)                    |                       |                      | 0.283 [0.208]      |                    |
| <b>N. Periphery <math>\times</math> Post</b> | 0.1789***<br>(0.0439) | 0.1604**<br>(0.0581) | 0.1096<br>(0.0723) | 0.0852<br>(0.0821) |
| <i>Controls</i>                              |                       |                      |                    |                    |
| Econ. Profile $\times$ Post                  | Yes                   | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                |
| Prefecture FE                                | Yes                   | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                |
| Month FE                                     | Yes                   | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>                        |                       |                      |                    |                    |
| Matched prefectures                          | 14                    | 14                   | 14                 | 14                 |
| Observations                                 | 406                   | 574                  | 868                | 1,106              |

Table A.9: NP Effect Is Robust to Seven-Covariate Cardinality Matching

**Note:** Matching-adjusted TWFE DD on cardinality-matched sample (all 7 covariates balanced within  $\pm 0.35$  SMD; 14 matched prefectures—all 7 treated, 7 controls) with economic profile covariates  $\times$  Post controls. The tolerance is relaxed from 0.25 to 0.35 to retain all treated prefectures; residual imbalance is absorbed by the doubly robust covariate  $\times$  Post controls. Sample restricted to matched prefectures (metropolitan areas excluded). Prefecture and month fixed effects; clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.



## C.6. Doubly Robust Difference-in-Differences

Table A.10 reports ATT estimates from the doubly robust DD estimator of (Sant'Anna and Zhao 2020), which combines inverse probability weighting with outcome regression. The estimator is consistent if either the propensity score model or the outcome regression model is correctly specified, providing a stronger robustness guarantee than approaches that rely on a single modeling strategy. Covariates are the same five used in the cardinality matching: rice dependence, economic shock (1929–1931), per-capita income (1931), agriculture dependence, and sharecropper rate. The sample is restricted to non-metropolitan prefectures (7 treated, 34 control), with the monthly panel collapsed to pre- and post-period means for each window.

The DR-DD ATT is 0.18 at +12 months ( $p < 0.05$ ) and 0.20 at +24 months ( $p < 0.05$ ), consistent with the baseline DD (0.20 and 0.24) and other covariate-adjusted estimators. Precision declines at longer horizons, reflecting the small treated group.

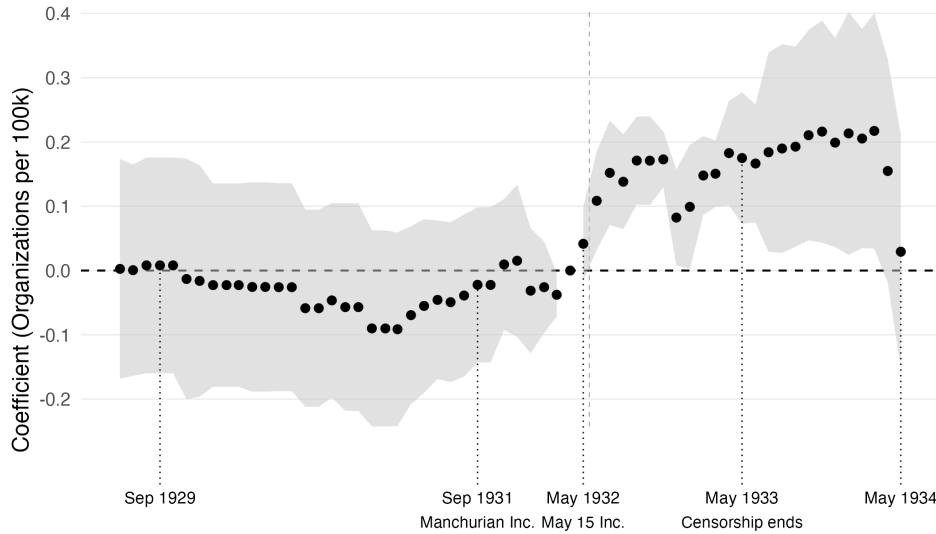


Figure A.16: Doubly Robust DD Event Study

**Note:** Doubly robust DD event study (Sant'Anna and Zhao 2020) with flat pre-trends and a sharp post-shock divergence, consistent with the baseline.

| Outcome                   | Org Density (per 100k) |          |               |          |
|---------------------------|------------------------|----------|---------------|----------|
| Model:                    | (1)                    | (2)      | (3)           | (4)      |
| Post-Treatment Period:    | +12m                   | +24m     | ~Feb 36       | ~Jul 37  |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD] (NP) |                        |          | 0.283 [0.208] |          |
| <b>Northern Periphery</b> | 0.1814**               | 0.1992** | 0.1712        | 0.1476   |
| <b>ATT</b>                | (0.0718)               | (0.0897) | (0.1213)      | (0.1332) |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>     |                        |          |               |          |
| Treated prefectures       | 7                      | 7        | 7             | 7        |
| Control prefectures       | 34                     | 34       | 34            | 34       |
| Pref. × month obs.        | 1,189                  | 1,681    | 3,280         | 3,239    |

Table A.10: Doubly Robust DD Confirms the Peripheral Surge

**Note:** Improved doubly robust DD (panel) estimator (Sant'Anna and Zhao 2020). The monthly panel is collapsed to pre- and post-period means for each window; the estimator differences out unit-level time-invariant confounders and uses five economic covariates (rice dependence, economic shock 1929–1931, per-capita income 1931, agriculture dependence, sharecropper rate) in both the inverse probability weighting and outcome regression models. Standard errors in parentheses. Non-metropolitan prefectures only. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.

## C.7. FE Counterfactual Estimator

The fixed effects counterfactual (FEct) estimator (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024) addresses two limitations of the standard TWFE event study. First, it avoids the negative-weights problem by fitting the two-way FE model only on untreated observations and imputing counterfactual outcomes for treated units. Second, its dynamic treatment effects plot is based on residuals ( $Y_{it} - \hat{Y}_{it}(0)$ ) rather than interaction coefficients, relaxing the constant-treatment-effect assumption implicit in the conventional event-study specification.

Figure A.17 shows the estimated period-specific ATTs with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals (200 iterations). Pre-treatment residuals are flat and centered on zero, consistent with parallel trends. The treatment effect emerges at the onset of the shock and stabilizes around 0.15–0.19 per 100,000 population, tracking the baseline DD. The overall ATT across the +24-month post-treatment window is 0.15 (SE = 0.07,  $p < 0.05$ ).

Figure A.18 reports the equivalence test for no pretrend (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024). The test hides pre-treatment periods sequentially and checks whether out-of-sample prediction errors fall within a pre-specified equivalence range ( $\pm 0.36\hat{\sigma}_\epsilon$ ). The placebo test cannot reject the null of zero pre-treatment effect ( $p = 0.70$ ), providing out-of-sample—and thus overfitting-immune—support for the identifying assumptions.

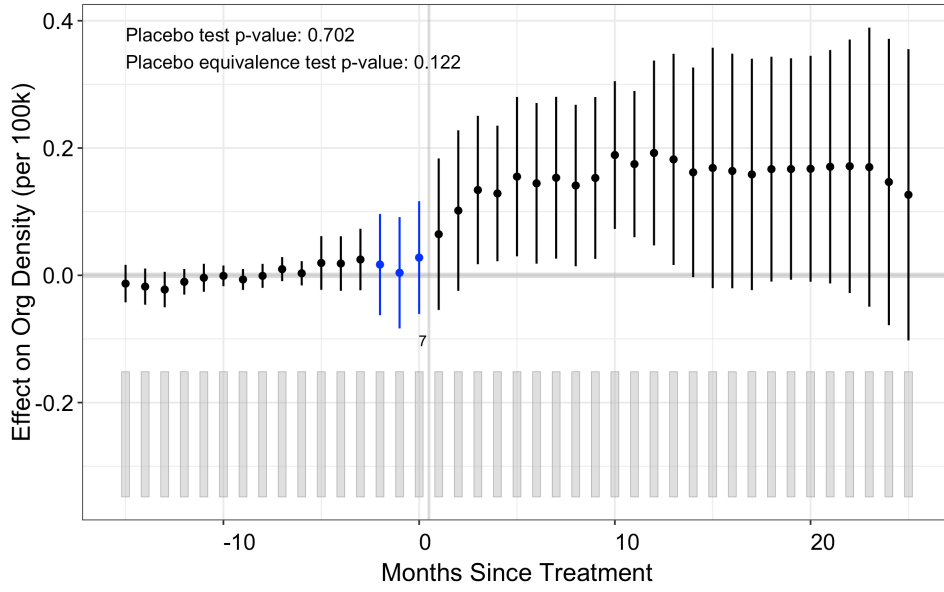


Figure A.17: FEct Dynamic Treatment Effects

**Note:** Period-specific ATT estimates from the FE counterfactual estimator (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024). Points: residual-based ATT ( $Y_{it} - \hat{Y}_{it}(0)$ ) averaged across treated units at each relative time period. Shaded region: 95% bootstrap confidence intervals (200 iterations). Bar plot at bottom: number of treated units. Placebo periods (blue) are hidden from model fitting and predicted out of sample.

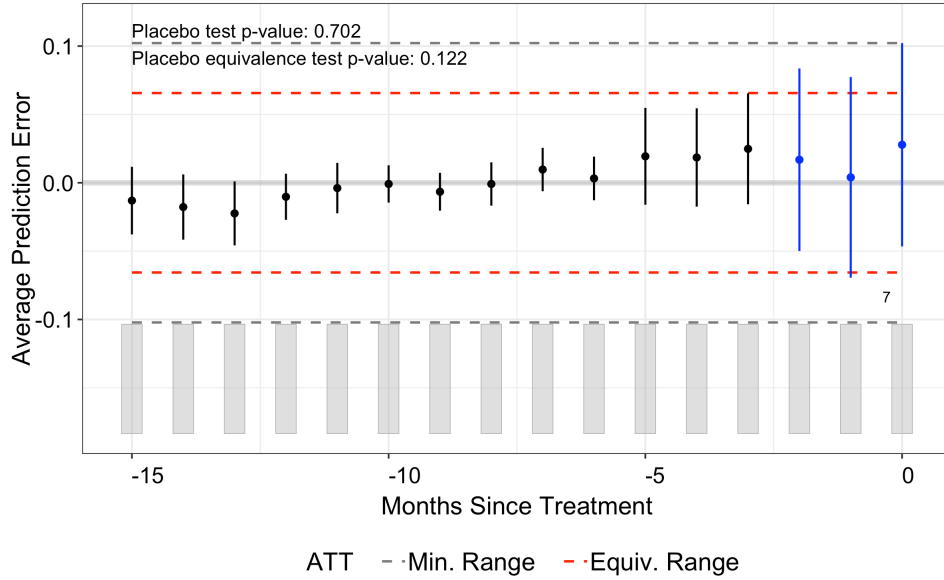


Figure A.18: FEct Equivalence Test Supports No Pretrend

**Note:** Leave-one-period-out pre-treatment prediction errors with 90% bootstrap confidence intervals. Red dashed lines: equivalence range ( $\pm 0.36\hat{\sigma}_\varepsilon$ ). Gray dashed lines: minimum range. Pre-treatment errors fall within the equivalence bounds, consistent with valid identifying assumptions. Placebo  $t$ -test  $p = 0.70$ ; equivalence (TOST)  $p = 0.12$ .

| Outcome                | Org Density (per 100k) |                      |                    |                    |
|------------------------|------------------------|----------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| Model:                 | (1)                    | (2)                  | (3)                | (4)                |
| Post-Treatment Period: | +12m                   | +24m                 | ~Feb 36            | ~Jul 37            |
| <b>FEct ATT</b>        | 0.1442***<br>(0.0553)  | 0.1511**<br>(0.0709) | 0.1460<br>(0.1048) | 0.1269<br>(0.1161) |
| 95% CI                 | [0.036, 0.253]         | [0.012, 0.290]       | [-0.059, 0.352]    | [-0.101, 0.355]    |
| Placebo equiv. $p$     |                        |                      | 0.70               |                    |
| Observations           | 1,363                  | 1,927                | 2,914              | 3,713              |
| Treated cells          | 91                     | 175                  | 322                | 441                |

Table A.11: FE Counterfactual Estimator Across Post-Treatment Windows

**Note:** FEct ATT estimates (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024) with 200 bootstrap iterations. FEct imputes  $Y(0)$  for treated observations using a TWFE model fitted only on untreated observations. The ATT averages over all post-treatment periods in each window, so estimates are mechanically smaller than the DD coefficient (which captures the average post-treatment level shift). Placebo equivalence  $p$ -value from the leave-periods-out test on the +24m specification. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

## C.8. Sensitivity to Parallel Trends Violations

Rambachan and Roth (2023) propose honest confidence intervals that remain valid under calibrated violations of parallel trends. I implement their relative magnitudes (RM) framework using the `HonestDiD` R package.

Under the RM approach, the breakdown value is  $\overline{M} = 0$ : the treatment effect loses significance at the smallest allowable post-treatment violation. The driver is the ratio between the maximum pre-treatment coefficient and the conventional CI's distance from zero. The conventional CI for the average post-treatment effect (at  $\overline{M} = 0$ ) is  $[0.114, 0.200]$ ; the maximum absolute pre-treatment coefficient is 0.089—78% of the lower bound. Allowing post-treatment violations just 10% as large as this worst pre-treatment violation ( $\overline{M} = 0.1$ ) widens the CI to  $[-0.040, 0.344]$ , already including zero. At  $\overline{M} = 1$  (post-treatment bias as large as the worst pre-treatment violation), the CI is  $[-0.366, 0.444]$ ; at  $\overline{M} = 2$ , it is  $[-0.444, 0.444]$ . With 7 treated clusters, the pre-treatment coefficients are estimated imprecisely, making the maximum pre-treatment coefficient—which governs the allowed post-treatment bias in the RM framework—a noisy upper bound on genuine trend violations.

This fragility does not invalidate the identification. The parallel trends assumption in this paper rests on three pieces of evidence that do not depend on the `HonestDiD` framework: (1) flat pre-trends during two years of severe agrarian depression, when an economic confounder would predict divergence; (2) the FEct equivalence test (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024), which provides out-of-sample validation immune to overfitting ( $p = 0.70$ ; Appendix C.7); and (3) the spatial permutation test, which rejects the null at  $p = 0.041$  even under the conservative spatially constrained design (Appendix C.1). The `HonestDiD` result is reported here for completeness; the identification argument does not rely on it.

## C.9. Membership-Weighted Organization Density

The baseline analysis uses organization counts per capita as the outcome. As an alternative, Table A.12 uses total membership (summed reported membership of existing organizations) per 100,000 population. About 48% of grassroots organizations report membership size; those without are dropped. Membership is winsorized at the 99th percentile to limit outlier influence.

Because individual membership sizes are highly variable, the outcome is log-transformed:  $\log(1 + \text{membership density per 100k})$ . The standard DD yields an NP  $\times$  Post coefficient of 0.99 log points at +12 months ( $p = 0.029$ ), corresponding to roughly a 170% increase in membership density. Cardinality matching on five economic covariates yields a matched coefficient of 1.26 log points ( $p < 0.001$ ), corresponding to a 252% increase. Both specifications remain stable and significant through the prewar endpoint (Table A.12). The event study (Figure A.19) shows flat pre-trends and a sharp discontinuity at the shock for both the standard and matched specifications.

| Outcome                            | Log(1 + members per 100k) |                    |                    |                    |                         |                     |                     |                     |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|-------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
|                                    | Standard DD               |                    |                    |                    | Cardinality Matching DD |                     |                     |                     |
| Model:                             | (1)                       | (2)                | (3)                | (4)                | (5)                     | (6)                 | (7)                 | (8)                 |
| Post-Treatment Period:             | +12m                      | +24m               | ~Feb 36            | ~Jul 37            | +12m                    | +24m                | ~Feb 36             | ~Jul 37             |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD]<br>(NP)       | 2.27 [1.85]               |                    |                    |                    |                         |                     |                     |                     |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post</b> | 0.990**<br>(0.429)        | 1.038**<br>(0.442) | 1.057**<br>(0.470) | 1.059**<br>(0.484) | 1.258***<br>(0.170)     | 1.299***<br>(0.124) | 1.206***<br>(0.093) | 1.188***<br>(0.109) |
| <i>Controls</i>                    |                           |                    |                    |                    |                         |                     |                     |                     |
| Metropolitan $\times$ Post         | Yes                       | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                | No                      | No                  | No                  | No                  |
| Econ. Profile $\times$ Post        | No                        | No                 | No                 | No                 | Yes                     | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Prefecture FE                      | Yes                       | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                     | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Month FE                           | Yes                       | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                | Yes                     | Yes                 | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Matched prefectures                | —                         | —                  | —                  | —                  | 12                      | 12                  | 12                  | 12                  |
| Observations                       | 1,363                     | 1,927              | 2,914              | 3,713              | 348                     | 492                 | 744                 | 948                 |
| $R^2$ (within)                     | 0.069                     | 0.062              | 0.052              | 0.048              | 0.495                   | 0.574               | 0.571               | 0.564               |

Table A.12: Membership-Weighted Organization Density

**Note:** Outcome:  $\log(1 + \text{total membership per 100k})$ . Only organizations with non-missing membership data are included (48% of grassroots orgs). Membership winsorized at 99th percentile. Columns 1–4: standard TWFE DD on all prefectures. Columns 5–8: cardinality matching (5 covariates,  $\text{SMD} < 0.25$ , 12 matched prefectures) with economic profile covariates  $\times$  Post. Clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

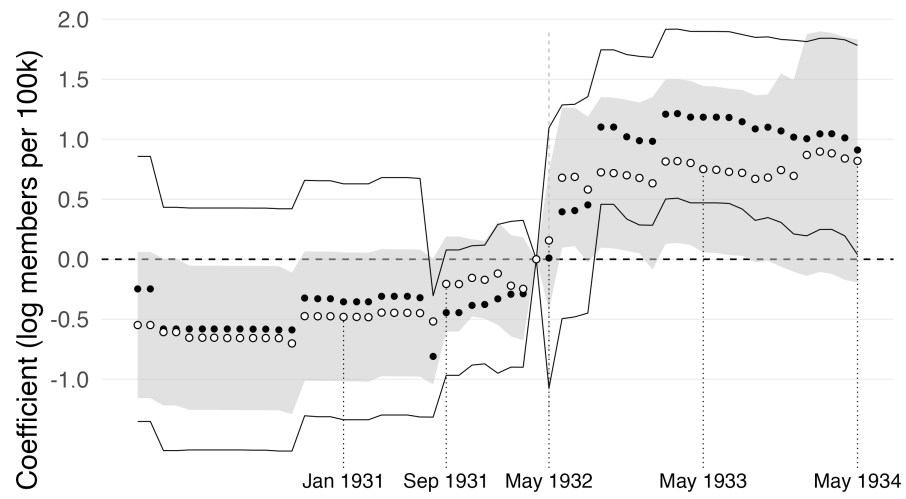


Figure A.19: Membership-Weighted Event Study (Log)

**Note:** Point estimates with 95% confidence intervals from the event-study specification using  $\log(1 + \text{membership density per } 100k)$  as the outcome. Open circles with light-gray CIs: standard DD; filled circles with dark-gray CIs: cardinality-matched DD. Reference period: April 1932.



## C.10. Metropolitan Event Study

Figure A.20 shows that metropolitan prefectures display pre-treatment trends and gradual growth, with no discontinuity at the shock date. The discrete jump is specific to the periphery.

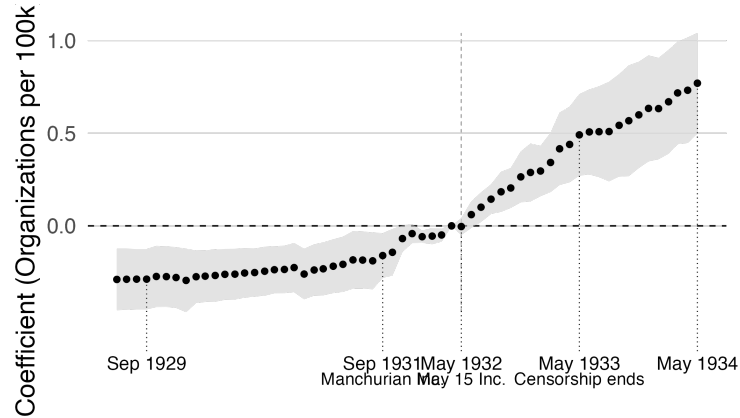


Figure A.20: Metropolitan Prefectures Show Pre-Trends, Not a Discontinuity

**Note:** Points show coefficient estimates with 95% confidence intervals from the event-study specification.

### C.11. Flow Event Study

Figure A.21 plots the event-study estimates using the flow of new grassroots right-wing organizations founded per month per 100,000 population as the outcome, rather than the stock of existing organizations. The stock measure captures the operative infrastructure at each point in time—counting every organization whose founding date falls on or before the period and whose dissolution date (if any) falls after—while the flow isolates the timing of new foundings. A 3-month centered moving average smooths the raw monthly counts, which are sparse (most prefecture-months have zero new foundings). The flow event study shows noisier coefficients than the stock, reflecting this sparseness. The NP founding differential spikes at the May 1932 shock then subsides; the sustained divergence in Figure 4 arises because founded organizations persist in the stock.

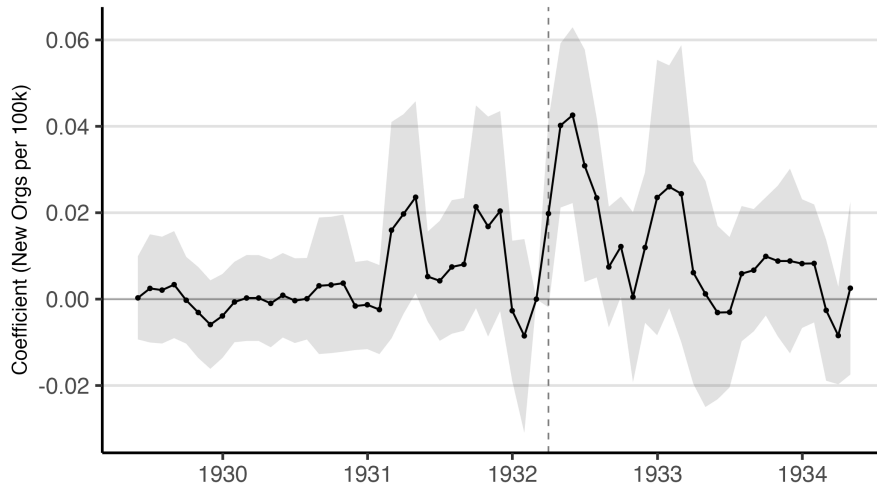


Figure A.21: Flow Event Study: New Organization Foundings per Month

**Note:** NP  $\times$  relative month coefficients with 95% confidence intervals. Outcome: 3-month centered moving average of newly founded grassroots right-wing organizations per 100,000 population. Reference period: April 1932. Dashed vertical line marks May 1932 (May 15 shock). The flow is inherently sparse—most prefecture-months have zero new foundings—so the stock measure (Figure 4) is the preferred specification for inference.

| Outcome                | New Orgs per 100k (3-mo MA) |                    |                     |                     |
|------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Model:                 | (1)                         | (2)                | (3)                 | (4)                 |
| Post-Treatment Window: | +12m                        | +24m               | ~Feb 36             | ~Jul 37             |
| Pre-treat. mean [NP]   |                             |                    | 0.016               |                     |
| <b>NP × Post</b>       | 0.0100<br>(0.0082)          | 0.0025<br>(0.0063) | −0.0022<br>(0.0056) | −0.0033<br>(0.0057) |
| <i>Controls</i>        |                             |                    |                     |                     |
| Metropolitan × Post    | Yes                         | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Prefecture FE          | Yes                         | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Month FE               | Yes                         | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>  |                             |                    |                     |                     |
| Observations           | 1,363                       | 1,927              | 2,914               | 3,713               |
| $R^2$                  | 0.402                       | 0.366              | 0.297               | 0.258               |

Table A.13: Flow DD: New Organization Foundings

**Note:** Unit of analysis: prefecture × month. Outcome: 3-month centered moving average of newly founded grassroots right-wing organizations per 100,000 population. The NP × Post coefficient is insignificant across all windows, reflecting the transient nature of the founding spike: new foundings surge at the shock but quickly subside. The stock measure captures the persistent infrastructure these foundings create. Clustered (prefecture & month) standard errors in parentheses. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.

## C.12. Full Coefficient Table

Table A.14 reports the full coefficient table for the main DiD specification, including all control variables. Columns 1–4 present the baseline TWFE DD on all prefectures; columns 5–8 present the cardinality-matched DD (5-covariate matching,  $SMD < 0.25$ , 12 matched prefectures) with the five matching covariates interacted with the post-shock indicator.

| Outcome                      | Org Density (per 100k) |                       |                       |                       |                                |                       |                      |                      |
|------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                              | <i>Standard DD</i>     |                       |                       |                       | <i>Cardinality Matching DD</i> |                       |                      |                      |
| Model:                       | (1)                    | (2)                   | (3)                   | (4)                   | (5)                            | (6)                   | (7)                  | (8)                  |
| Post-Treatment Period:       | +12m                   | +24m                  | ~Feb 36               | ~Jul 37               | +12m                           | +24m                  | ~Feb 36              | ~Jul 37              |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD]<br>(NP) | 0.283 [0.208]          |                       |                       |                       |                                |                       |                      |                      |
| <b>NP × Post</b>             | 0.2029***<br>(0.0497)  | 0.2362***<br>(0.0618) | 0.2629***<br>(0.0950) | 0.2588**<br>(0.1052)  | 0.2042***<br>(0.0309)          | 0.2310***<br>(0.0409) | 0.2447**<br>(0.0838) | 0.2526**<br>(0.1028) |
| Metropolitan × Post          | 0.3912***<br>(0.1146)  | 0.5676***<br>(0.1430) | 0.7796***<br>(0.1497) | 0.8789***<br>(0.1465) |                                |                       |                      |                      |
| Econ. Shock × Post           |                        |                       |                       |                       | 10.65<br>(15.65)               | 14.67<br>(23.80)      | 13.04<br>(42.72)     | 7.25<br>(52.70)      |
| Rice Share × Post            |                        |                       |                       |                       | 0.651<br>(0.553)               | 0.543<br>(1.084)      | 1.284<br>(2.119)     | 1.646<br>(2.641)     |
| Sharecropper Rate ×<br>Post  |                        |                       |                       |                       | 0.374***<br>(0.117)            | 0.617**<br>(0.201)    | 0.798*<br>(0.454)    | 0.821<br>(0.549)     |
| Income 1931 pc × Post        |                        |                       |                       |                       | −25.11***<br>(3.86)            | −31.01***<br>(6.46)   | −46.94***<br>(14.40) | −53.57***<br>(17.74) |
| Agri. Dependence × Post      |                        |                       |                       |                       | −1.970***<br>(0.400)           | −2.100**<br>(0.848)   | −2.834<br>(1.902)    | −2.872<br>(2.338)    |
| Prefecture FE                | Yes                    | Yes                   | Yes                   | Yes                   | Yes                            | Yes                   | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Month FE                     | Yes                    | Yes                   | Yes                   | Yes                   | Yes                            | Yes                   | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Matched prefectures          | —                      | —                     | —                     | —                     | 12                             | 12                    | 12                   | 12                   |
| Observations                 | 1,363                  | 1,927                 | 2,914                 | 3,713                 | 348                            | 492                   | 744                  | 948                  |

Table A.14: Full Coefficient Table

**Note:** Columns 1–4: TWFE DD on all prefectures with Metropolitan × Post control only. Columns 5–8: matching-adjusted TWFE DD on cardinality-matched non-metropolitan sample ( $SMD$  tolerance 0.25; 12 matched prefectures) with the five matching covariates × Post. Prefecture and month fixed effects; clustered (Prefecture & Month) standard errors. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

## D. PARLIAMENTARY SPEECH ANALYSIS

Historians document that establishment politicians struck Faustian bargains during this period, co-opting antiparty hostility to outmaneuver internal rivals, with both major parties moving “steadily to the right,” “outflanking each other to support army action,” and “marginalizing liberal internationalists” (Young 2024, p. 132). Given electoral incentives, MPs from prefectures where Imperial Way organizations proliferated had reason to accommodate the new ideological environment—and this accommodation should be disproportionately visible among NP politicians, where the organizational surge was concentrated.

I classify 611,146 lower-house speeches spanning 1920–1945 using a fine-tuned BERT classifier trained on three categories (pro-military, autocratic, and other) and match elected candidates to their speech records across election terms 14–21. The classifier achieves strong performance on autocratic content ( $F1 = 0.72$ ) but weaker performance on pro-military content ( $F1 = 0.37$ ), reflecting the difficulty of distinguishing ideological militarism from routine military policy discussion; [Appendix I](#) validates that this does not bias the cross-prefectural comparison, since the combined right-wing share used here aggregates both categories.<sup>[14]</sup> [Figure A.22](#) plots the mean right-wing speech share by election term, averaging across prefecture-level means so that each prefecture receives equal weight. Before the shock, the northern periphery and other prefectures track closely. After the 19th election (1936), a gap opens: MPs from northern periphery prefectures shift further rightward than those from the rest of the country, and the divergence persists through the wartime 21st election (1942). The overlaid bars show that radical-right vote shares are comparable or higher outside the northern periphery, so vote shifts toward radical-right parties cannot explain the speech divergence.

I aggregate to the prefecture  $\times$  election-term level—matching the plot—and estimate a standard difference-in-differences:

---

<sup>[14]</sup>Candidates are matched by name between the election records and Diet proceedings. Of 979 matched elected speakers, 566 (58%) appear in multiple terms. For each speaker  $\times$  election term, I compute the sentence-weighted share of pro-military and autocratic speech. Non-speakers are coded as zero. [Appendix I](#) describes the classifier architecture and validation.

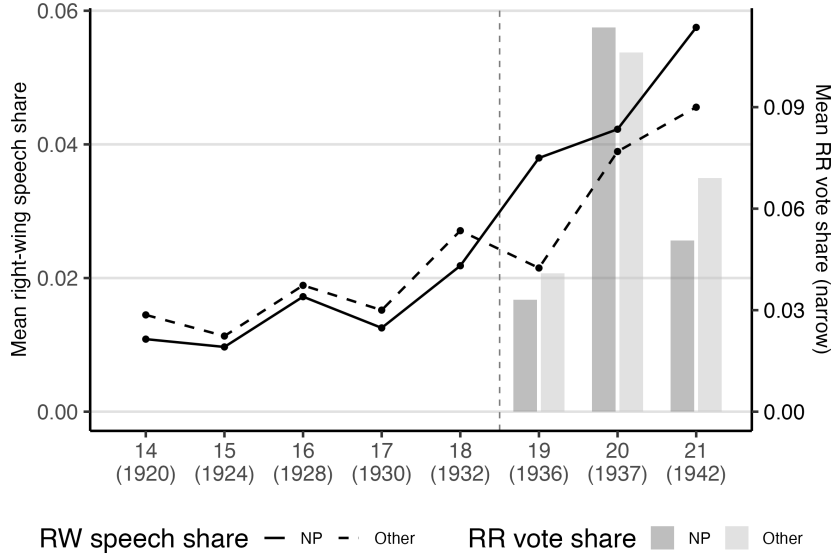


Figure A.22: Right-Wing Speech Diverges in the Northern Periphery

**Note:** Lines (left axis): mean right-wing speech share across election terms 14–21 (1920–1942). Bars (right axis): mean radical-right vote share (narrow definition, excluding Shōwakai and Kokumin Dōmei). For each prefecture  $\times$  election term, I average across all elected MPs (non-speakers coded as zero for speech), then average across prefectures within each group. Northern periphery: Aomori, Iwate, Miyagi, Akita, Yamagata, Fukushima, Niigata.

$$\overline{\text{RWShare}}_{p,t} = \beta(\text{NP}_p \times \text{Post}_t) + \alpha_p + \psi_t + \varepsilon_{p,t}$$

where  $\overline{\text{RWShare}}_{p,t}$  is the mean right-wing speech share across all elected MPs from prefecture  $p$  in election term  $t$  (non-speakers coded as zero),  $\text{NP}_p$  indicates the seven northern periphery prefectures, and  $\text{Post}_t$  equals one for election terms 19–21. Prefecture and election fixed effects absorb time-invariant prefecture differences and common shocks across elections. Standard errors are clustered by prefecture.

At the election-term level (columns 1–2), the  $\text{NP} \times \text{Post}$  coefficient is 0.016 among speakers and 0.014 among all elected MPs—but not statistically significant ( $p = 0.35$  and 0.16), reflecting the limited power of 7 treated prefectures observed over 8 election terms. Columns 3–4 re-estimate the same specification on a prefecture  $\times$  year panel (post = 1933 onward), which provides substantially more time variation. The yearly estimates are 0.022 among speakers ( $p = 0.047$ ) and 0.009 among all elected ( $p = 0.043$ ; wild cluster bootstrap one-sided  $p = 0.029$ ). Randomization inference permuting the NP label across 5,000 random draws of 7 prefectures yields a one-sided  $p$ -value of 0.079 (two-

| Outcome                            | Mean RW Speech Share (prefecture level) |                    |                      |                      |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
|                                    | (1)                                     | (2)                | (3)                  | (4)                  |
| Panel                              | Election Term                           |                    | Year                 |                      |
| Sample                             | Speakers                                | All Elected        | Speakers             | All Elected          |
| Pre-treat. mean [SD]               | 0.042 [0.031]                           | 0.024 [0.031]      | 0.047 [0.021]        | 0.020 [0.021]        |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post</b> | 0.0159<br>(0.0169)                      | 0.0138<br>(0.0097) | 0.0220**<br>(0.0108) | 0.0093**<br>(0.0045) |
| <i>Controls</i>                    |                                         |                    |                      |                      |
| Prefecture FE                      | Yes                                     | Yes                | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| Period FE                          | Yes                                     | Yes                | Yes                  | Yes                  |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>              |                                         |                    |                      |                      |
| Observations                       | 365                                     | 368                | 1,164                | 1,196                |
| $R^2$                              | 0.340                                   | 0.237              | 0.183                | 0.149                |

Table A.15: Northern Periphery MPs Shift Rightward After the Shock

**Note:** DV: mean right-wing speech share across elected MPs from the prefecture. “Speakers” averages over MPs who spoke at least once; “All Elected” includes non-speakers coded as zero. Columns 1–2: prefecture  $\times$  election term (terms 14–21); Post = elections 19–21. Columns 3–4: prefecture  $\times$  year (1920–1945); Post = 1933 onward. All specifications include prefecture and period fixed effects. SEs clustered by prefecture. .\*\*\*: 0.01, .\*\*: 0.05, .\*: 0.1.

sided  $p = 0.155$ ), indicating that the speech result is suggestive but not robust to exact inference—consistent with the limited power of 7 treated clusters.<sup>[15]</sup> Replacing the NP indicator with continuous pre-treatment Imperial Way organizational density produces null results (Appendix E), indicating that the speech shift is associated with the NP-specific mobilization process rather than with organizational infrastructure generically.

<sup>[15]</sup>NP-prefecture MPs’ speeches have a slightly higher pre-treatment right-wing classification rate (2.1% vs. 1.6%), consistent with the regional salience of military topics near the 8th Division. This level difference is absorbed by prefecture fixed effects; the DD identifies the *change* in classification rates, which requires only that any differential misclassification be stable over time. Stratifying the classifier’s predicted right-wing sentence share by NP status confirms that misclassification is not differential: the overall right-wing share is 1.90% for NP speeches and 1.84% for non-NP speeches, a difference small enough to be attributable to content rather than systematic classifier bias.

| Outcome                                     | Mean RW Speech Share (prefecture level) |                    |                     |                     |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
|                                             | (1)                                     | (2)                | (3)                 | (4)                 |
| Panel                                       | Election Term                           |                    | Year                |                     |
| Sample                                      | Speakers                                | All Elected        | Speakers            | All Elected         |
| <b>IWF Density <math>\times</math> Post</b> | 0.1072*<br>(0.0638)                     | 0.0228<br>(0.0589) | −0.0086<br>(0.0758) | −0.0142<br>(0.0252) |
| <i>Controls</i>                             |                                         |                    |                     |                     |
| Prefecture FE                               | Yes                                     | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| Period FE                                   | Yes                                     | Yes                | Yes                 | Yes                 |
| <i>Fit Statistics</i>                       |                                         |                    |                     |                     |
| Observations                                | 329                                     | 368                | 1,126               | 1,149               |
| $R^2$                                       | 0.237                                   | 0.232              | 0.187               | 0.142               |

Table A.16: Pre-Existing Imperial Way Organizational Density Does Not Predict Speech Radicalization

**Note:** Same specification as Table A.15 with continuous pre-treatment Imperial Way organizational density (mean across election terms 14–18, per 100,000 population) replacing the NP binary. Columns 1–2: prefecture  $\times$  election term (terms 14–21); Post = elections 19–21. Columns 3–4: prefecture  $\times$  year (1920–1945); Post = 1933 onward. SEs clustered by prefecture. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

## E. ORGANIZATIONAL DENSITY PLACEBO: SPEECH

If the parliamentary radicalization result in Table A.15 reflects a generic relationship between pre-existing organizational infrastructure and speech content—rather than the post-shock mobilization specific to the northern periphery—then replacing the NP indicator with a continuous measure of pre-treatment Imperial Way organizational density should produce comparable effects. Table A.16 tests this by estimating the same specification as Table A.15 with mean pre-treatment Imperial Way organizational density (per 100,000 population, averaged across election terms 14–18) in place of the NP binary.

The coefficients are insignificant in every specification except the underpowered election-term speakers panel (column 1,  $p < 0.10$ ). In the year panel (columns 3–4), where the NP treatment is significant, the Imperial Way density coefficients are slightly negative. Figure A.23 confirms visually: prefectures with any pre-treatment Imperial Way organizational presence track those without it closely, with no post-shock divergence.



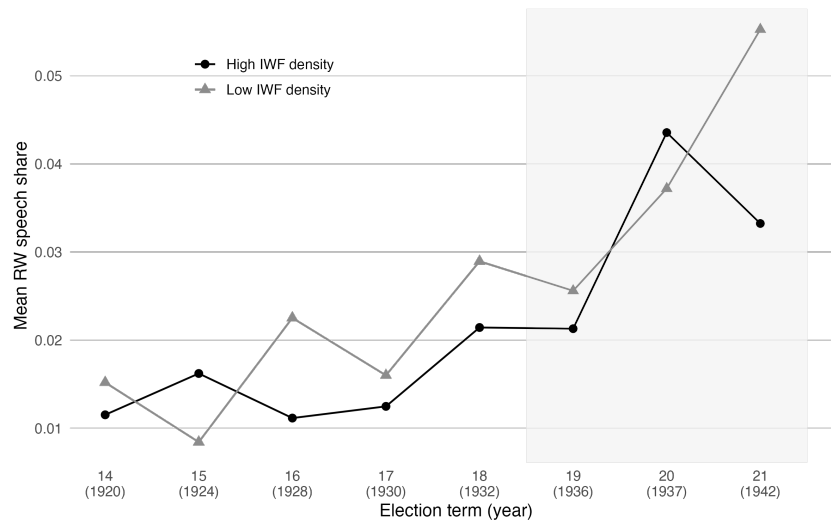


Figure A.23: No Speech Divergence by Pre-Treatment Imperial Way Organizational Density

**Note:** Mean right-wing speech share by election term for prefectures with and without pre-treatment Imperial Way organizations (presence defined as mean Imperial Way organizational density  $> 0$  across election terms 14–18). Shaded region marks the post-treatment period (elections 19–21).

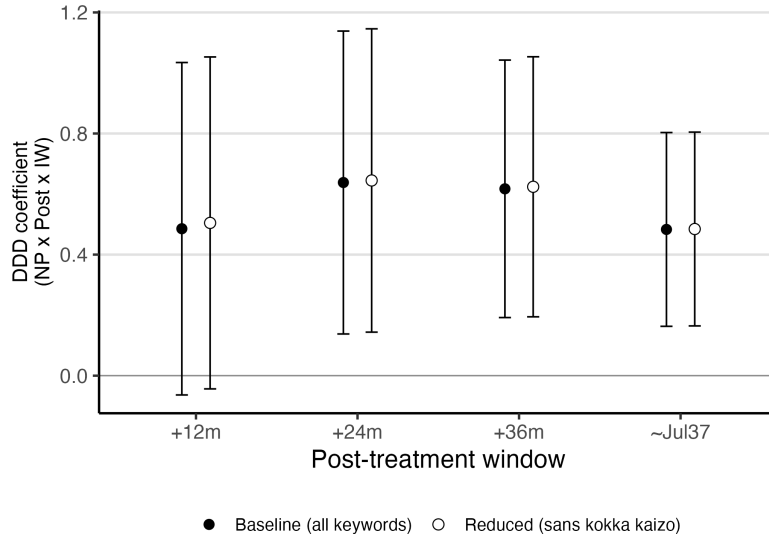


Figure A.24: DDD Is Insensitive to Excluding the Most Ambiguous Keyword

**Note:** Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals for the DDD coefficient ( $\text{NP} \times \text{Post} \times \text{Imperial Way type}$ ) across four post-treatment windows. Filled circles: baseline classification using all five keywords. Open circles: reduced classification excluding *kokka kaizō* (state reconstruction). All specifications include prefecture  $\times$  type and quarter  $\times$  type fixed effects, with standard errors two-way clustered by prefecture and quarter.

## F. DDD KEYWORD SENSITIVITY

The DDD result in Table 2 classifies organizations as Imperial Way using five keywords. The most potentially ambiguous is *kokka kaizō* (state reconstruction), which appears in Kita Ikki’s 1919 manifesto and was occasionally used by non-Kōdōha nationalists. Figure A.24 repeats the DDD excluding *kokka kaizō*, retaining only four keywords: *kōdō*, *Shōwa ishin*, *seitō kaishō*, and *tennō shinsei*.

Across all four windows, the reduced-keyword estimates are virtually identical to the baseline: 0.50 vs. 0.49 at +12 months, 0.64 vs. 0.64 at +24 months, 0.62 vs. 0.62 through February 1936, and 0.48 vs. 0.48 through the prewar endpoint. Removing *kokka kaizō* slightly *increases* the point estimates, confirming that the compositional result is not driven by this ambiguous term.

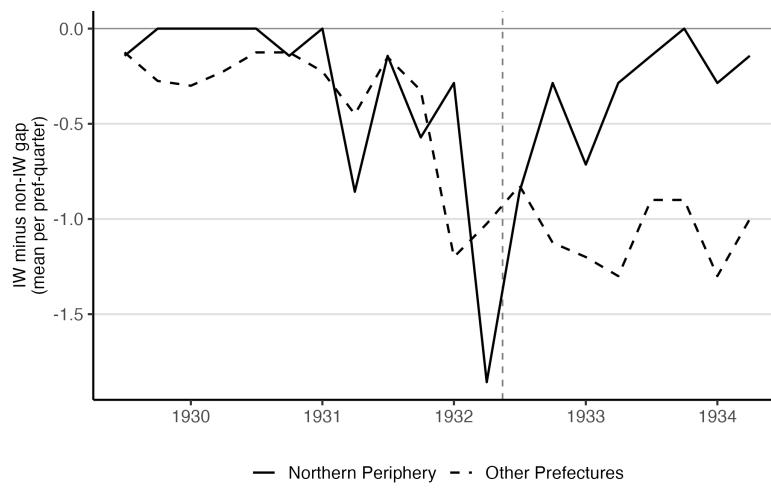


Figure A.25: DDD Identifying Variation at Raw Quarterly Frequency

**Note:** IW-minus-non-IW founding gap (mean per prefecture-quarter) at raw quarterly frequency, matching the data that enters the DDD regression. Solid: northern periphery; dashed: all other prefectures. Dashed vertical line marks May 15, 1932. [Figure 5](#) panel (b) shows the same quantity smoothed with a four-quarter centered moving average.

|                                                           | (1)               | (2)                | (3)                 | (4)                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Post-Treatment Period:                                    | +12m              | +24m               | ~Feb 36             | ~Jul 37             |
| <i>Flow (new foundings)</i>                               |                   |                    |                     |                     |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post <math>\times</math> IW</b> | 0.485*<br>(0.280) | 0.638**<br>(0.255) | 0.617***<br>(0.217) | 0.483***<br>(0.163) |
| <i>Stock (existing orgs)</i>                              |                   |                    |                     |                     |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post <math>\times</math> IW</b> | 4.329<br>(2.910)  | 5.570<br>(3.608)   | 6.634<br>(4.081)    | 8.574<br>(4.740)    |

Table A.17: DDD: Flow vs. Stock Measure

**Note:** Flow outcome: count of newly founded organizations per prefecture-quarter-type. Stock outcome: count of existing organizations per prefecture-quarter-type (raw counts, not per capita). Both specifications include prefecture  $\times$  type and quarter  $\times$  type fixed effects, with standard errors two-way clustered by prefecture and quarter. \*\*\*: 0.01, \*\*: 0.05, \*: 0.1.

## G. STOCK-BASED DDD

The main DDD uses the flow of new foundings per prefecture-quarter-type because ideology is classified at the time of founding. As a robustness check, I replicate the DDD using the stock measure (number of existing organizations of each type) as the outcome. The stock-based DDD asks whether the standing IW share in the NP diverged after the shock, rather than whether new foundings were disproportionately IW.

The stock-based DDD coefficient is positive at every window and grows over time as newly founded IW organizations accumulate in the stock. It reaches marginal significance ( $p = 0.077$ ) at the longest window. The attenuation relative to the flow measure is expected: pre-treatment non-IW organizations that persist in the stock dilute the post-shock compositional shift. The consistency in sign across both measures confirms that the IW-specific surge documented in the main text is not an artifact of the flow measure.

|                                                           | (1)              | (2)              | (3)              | (4)              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|------------------|------------------|
| Post-Treatment Period:                                    | +12m             | +24m             | ~Feb 36          | ~Jul 37          |
| <b>NP <math>\times</math> Post <math>\times</math> IW</b> | 0.522<br>(0.273) | 0.594<br>(0.260) | 0.550<br>(0.204) | 0.483<br>(0.163) |
| Cluster-robust $p$                                        | 0.066            | 0.029            | 0.010            | 0.005            |
| Randomization inference $p$ (one-sided)                   | 0.126            | 0.030            | 0.013            | < 0.001          |
| Randomization inference $p$ (two-sided)                   | 0.405            | 0.273            | 0.232            | 0.192            |

Table A.18: DDD Randomization Inference Across Post-Treatment Windows

**Note:** 5,000 permutations of the NP label across 40 non-NP prefectures. Cluster-robust  $p$ -values are two-way clustered by prefecture and quarter. One-sided  $p$ : fraction of permutation draws with  $\beta_1 \geq \text{observed}$ . Two-sided  $p$ : fraction with  $|\beta_1| \geq |\text{observed}|$ .

## H. DDD RANDOMIZATION INFERENCE ACROSS WINDOWS

Table A.18 reports the full progression across all four post-treatment windows. The test permutes the NP label across 5,000 random draws of 7 from 40 non-NP prefectures, matching the analysis sample. Since the hypothesis is directional—the NP should gain more IW organizations after the shock, not fewer—I report both one-sided and two-sided  $p$ -values.

The one-sided RI  $p$ -value reaches significance from +24 months onward (0.030) and strengthens to  $p < 0.001$  at the prewar endpoint. The two-sided  $p$ -values are larger because the permutation distribution includes draws where metro prefectures (with higher organizational density baselines) receive the NP label, generating large negative DDD coefficients that inflate the two-sided tail. The one-sided test is the appropriate standard for a directional hypothesis, and its progression—strengthening monotonically as the IW organizational advantage cumulates—is consistent with a real effect rather than a spurious spike.

## I. BERT SPEECH CLASSIFIER

The right-wing speech measures used in [Table A.15](#) are generated by a fine-tuned BERT classifier that labels each sentence in the lower-house Diet proceedings as *pro-military*, *autocratic*, or *other*. This section documents the classification pipeline, category definitions, model architecture, and validation performance.

### I.1. Classification Categories

The classifier assigns each sentence to one of three categories:

1. **Pro-military** (label 0). Militarist ideology: advocacy of military expansion, glorification of military force, or aggressive expansionism as a positive goal (e.g., 軍國主義, 皇軍, 聖戰, 膺懲). Routine budget or personnel discussions without ideological framing are excluded.
2. **Autocratic** (label 1). Opposition to parliamentary democracy and advocacy of authoritarian alternatives: Imperial Way ideology (皇道), Shōwa Restoration (昭和維新), dissolution of political parties (政黨解消), national reconstruction (國家改造), kokutai defense (國體擁護), national socialism (國家社會主義), and Imperial Rule Assistance (翼賛). General patriotism without autocratic content is excluded.
3. **Other** (label 2). All remaining content: routine policy discussion, parliamentary procedure, general patriotism, and social or economic debate.

When a sentence contains elements of both pro-military and autocratic, it is assigned to the category more central to its meaning, with ties broken in favor of autocratic.

[Table A.19](#) presents representative examples from the training set.

| Class        | Original                                                                                           | Translation                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pro-military | 凶作一家ヲ破ルモ、國策國難ニ臨ンデハ酷寒滿蒙ノ最先出征ニ從ヒ、父兄ハ喜ンデ之ヲ送り、健兒ハ勇ンデ死地ニ就ク<br>— Rep. Kumagai, 1934                      | Though crop failure ruins the family, when national crisis calls they are the first to march into the bitter cold of Manchuria and Mongolia; fathers gladly send them off, and stalwart sons bravely go to their deaths.            |
| Pro-military | 滿洲事變ヲヤツテ退ケタ軍部デスヨ、今迄ノ傳統的の屈從外交ヲ、カデ以テ轉同シタ軍部デスヨ、ダカラ何カヤルダラウト大衆ハ期待シテ居ル<br>— Rep. Nakano, 1934            | This is the military that carried out the Manchuria Incident! That used force to overturn our subservient diplomacy! The masses expect them to act.                                                                                 |
| Pro-military | 此日本帝國ノ此皇軍ノ行動ヲ先ヅ前提ニ置イテ、曲我ニ在リト云フ立場ニ於テ、他ノ審制ニ之ヲ委ネルト云フコトデアルナラバ此派遣軍ノ名譽ハ全ク蹂躪セラルハ<br>— Rep. Nakamura, 1929 | If we presume from the outset that the Imperial Army’s actions were wrong and submit to foreign arbitration, the honor of our expeditionary forces will be utterly trampled.                                                        |
| Autocratic   | 堅忍不拔ノ國民性ヲ醸成セントセバ、皇道ヲ基調トシテ思想善導ニ努ム可カラザルコト明々白々ノ道理ナラズヤ<br>— Rep. Kageyama, 1935                        | Is it not patently obvious that to cultivate an indomitable national character we must strive for thought guidance based on the Imperial Way?                                                                                       |
| Autocratic   | 其思想ガ表面ニ現ハレテ、サウシテ安寧秩序ヲ害スル、國體ニ反スルト云フコトニナレバ、罰スルコトハ私ハ當然ト思フ<br>— Education Minister Matsuda, 1935       | If such thoughts [ <i>i.e.</i> , <i>ideologies deemed subversive under the Peace Preservation Law</i> ] manifest outwardly and harm public order, or contravene the national polity, then I consider their punishment only natural. |
| Autocratic   | サウナリマスレバ、ドウシテモ美濃部君ノ説ハ國體ニ反スルモノダト云フコトニ結論セザルヲ得ヌデハゴザイマスマイカ<br>— Rep. Takeuchi, 1935                    | If that is the case, must we not inevitably conclude that Professor Minobe’s theory <sup>[16]</sup> contravenes the national polity?                                                                                                |
| Other        | 肥料管理法ニモ、何カ資金ノ調達ノ爲ニ、債券類似ノモノヲ發行スルカ云フヤウナコトガアリマスガ、サウ云フコトハナイノデスカ<br>— Rep. Takeuchi, 1929               | Does the Fertilizer Control Act also provide for issuing bond-like instruments to raise funds, or is there no such provision?                                                                                                       |
| Other        | 總テ實施設計ト云フモノニ付テハ何等御調査ニナラズシテ、實地調査モシナイデオヤリニナリマスカ<br>— Chair Ōta, 1926                                 | Do you proceed without any investigation of the implementation plans, without even conducting a field survey?                                                                                                                       |
| Other        | 所得稅ヲ財源ニ使ハレル國防計畫ノ陸海軍ノ豫算ニ就テ數字ヲ簡單デアルガ承リタイ<br>— Rep. Ōguchi, 1920                                      | I would like to hear briefly the figures on army and navy budgets for the national defense plan financed by income tax.                                                                                                             |

Table A.19: Example Sentences from the BERT Training Set

**Note:** Three representative sentences per class from the labeled training data. Sentences are drawn from lower-house Diet proceedings (1918–1937).

## I.2. Pipeline

The classification pipeline proceeds in five steps:

1. **Candidate sampling.** The full speech corpus (1.85 million records, 1918–1937) is streamed and segmented into sentences. Candidates are drawn from seven pools: two tiers of keyword matches per category (core and broad), hard negatives (non-keyword sentences from speeches that contain keywords elsewhere), easy negatives (sentences from keyword-free speeches), and a corpus-random reservoir sample. This yields approximately 3,000 candidate sentences.

<sup>[16]</sup>Minobe Tatsukichi’s Emperor-as-Organ Theory (*tennō kikan-setsu*): the constitutional doctrine that the emperor was an organ of the state rather than its sovereign. Suppressed in the 1935 *kokutai meicho* (national polity clarification) campaign.

2. **RAG indexing.** Markdown descriptions and structured records of known right-wing organizations are indexed into a vector store (ChromaDB with multilingual-e5-base embeddings) to provide contextual reference during labeling.
3. **Manual labeling.** Each candidate sentence is read alongside the five most similar right-wing organization descriptions retrieved from the vector store. The author classifies the sentence into the three categories, recording a label and brief reasoning. This yields a final training set of 7,126 labeled sentences.
4. **Fine-tuning.** A pre-trained Japanese BERT model (`tohoku-nlp/bert-base-japanese-v3`) is fine-tuned with a three-class linear head on the labeled data. Training uses balanced class weights to address class imbalance, AdamW optimization with learning rate  $2 \times 10^{-5}$ , gradient clipping at 1.0, and macro F1 as the model selection criterion.
5. **Full-corpus inference.** The fine-tuned model is applied to all 460,528 sentences from 375,377 lower-house speeches (1918–1937). For each sentence, the model outputs three-class probabilities; for each speech, sentence-level predictions are aggregated into counts and shares of pro-military, autocratic, and right-wing content.

### I.3. Model Architecture and Training

The model consists of a pre-trained BERT encoder (`tohoku-nlp/bert-base-japanese-v3`, pre-trained on Japanese Wikipedia by the Tohoku NLP Group) followed by dropout ( $p = 0.1$ ) and a linear projection from the [CLS] token representation to three output logits. The 7,126 labeled sentences are split into a training set (5,700 sentences, 80%) and a validation set (1,426 sentences, 20%) using a stratified random split. Cross-entropy loss with inverse-frequency class weights ( $w_{\text{mil}} = 3.58$ ,  $w_{\text{antidem}} = 2.96$ ,  $w_{\text{other}} = 0.42$ ) addresses the imbalance between the dominant *other* class and the two substantive categories.

Table A.20 reports the training history. Validation macro F1 peaks at epoch 3 (0.692) before declining, indicating overfitting. The epoch-3 checkpoint is selected as the final model.



| Epoch | Train Loss | Val Macro F1 | Selected |
|-------|------------|--------------|----------|
| 1     | 0.695      | 0.569        |          |
| 2     | 0.496      | 0.642        |          |
| 3     | 0.380      | 0.692        | ✓        |
| 4     | 0.243      | 0.668        |          |
| 5     | 0.177      | 0.661        |          |

Table A.20: Training History

**Note:** Validation macro F1 peaks at epoch 3 before overfitting sets in. Training on 5,700 labeled sentences with balanced class weights and AdamW ( $\text{lr} = 2 \times 10^{-5}$ , max sequence length = 256 tokens). Model selected at highest validation macro F1.

## I.4. Validation Performance

Table A.21 reports classification performance on the held-out validation set (1,426 sentences). Overall accuracy is 82%, with weighted F1 of 0.82. The *other* class, which comprises 79% of the validation set, achieves the highest performance ( $\text{F1} = 0.89$ ). The *autocratic* class performs well ( $\text{F1} = 0.72$ ), while the *pro-military* class is weaker ( $\text{F1} = 0.37$ ), reflecting both its smaller sample size (132 validation examples) and the difficulty of distinguishing ideological militarism from routine military policy discussion. The macro-averaged F1 is 0.66.

| Class            | Precision | Recall | F1   | Support |
|------------------|-----------|--------|------|---------|
| Pro-military     | 0.35      | 0.39   | 0.37 | 132     |
| Autocratic       | 0.72      | 0.73   | 0.72 | 161     |
| Other            | 0.89      | 0.88   | 0.89 | 1,133   |
| Accuracy         |           |        | 0.82 | 1,426   |
| Macro average    | 0.66      | 0.67   | 0.66 | 1,426   |
| Weighted average | 0.82      | 0.82   | 0.82 | 1,426   |

Table A.21: BERT Classifier Validation Performance

**Note:** Per-class and aggregate metrics on the held-out validation set. Validation set (20% stratified holdout,  $n = 1,426$ ). Labels from manual annotation. Precision, recall, and F1 computed per class; macro and weighted averages across classes.

The relatively low pro-military F1 is unlikely to bias the main speech analysis, which aggregates pro-military and autocratic predictions into a combined right-wing speech share. Any pro-military sentences misclassified as *other* reduce the level of measured right-wing speech but do not affect the cross-prefectural variation that identifies the coefficient in Table A.15, provided misclassification rates are uncorrelated with organizational density.

## J. FACTION AND CONSPIRACY PERSONNEL ROSTERS

This appendix lists the personnel rosters used in the faction–organization network analysis (Section 4.2). Table A.22 lists all Imperial Way faction members whose names appear in the right-wing organization source data, including both those not tried for the February 26 incident and the 41 persons tried by court-martial. Table A.24 lists the Control Faction core members appearing in organization data. Home prefecture is the registered domicile (*honseki*); officers from outside the northern periphery who were stationed there are discussed in the text. Sources: Shillony (1973), Kitaoka (2021), Kitabatake court records, Kotobank biographical database.

| Org                                           | Name  | Romanized           | Rank                | Home             | Feb. 26  | NP Link                    |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------|---------------------|---------------------|------------------|----------|----------------------------|
| <i>Tried: civilian</i>                        |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
| ✓                                             | 北一輝   | Kita Ikki           | —                   | Niigata          | Executed | Home                       |
| <i>Senior leaders (not tried)</i>             |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
| ✓                                             | 荒木貞夫  | Araki Sadao         | General             | Tokyo            | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 眞崎甚三郎 | Mazaki Jinzaburō    | General             | Saga             | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 柳川平助  | Yanagawa Heisuke    | Lt. Gen.            | Saga             | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 小畑敏四郎 | Obata Toshishirō    | Maj. Gen.           | Kōchi            | —        | —                          |
| <i>Young officer movement (not tried)</i>     |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
| ✓                                             | 大岸頼好  | Ōgishi Yoriyoshi    | Captain             | Kōchi            | —        | Posted: 5th Regt           |
| ✓                                             | 藤井齊   | Fujii Hitoshi       | Lt. Cmdr. (N)       | Saga             | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 古賀清志  | Koga Kiyoshi        | Lt. (Navy)          | Saga             | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 三上卓   | Mikami Taku         | Lt. (Navy)          | Saga             | —        | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 野田又男  | Noda Matao          | —                   | —                | —        | —                          |
| <i>Tried: former officers</i>                 |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
|                                               | 磯部浅一  | Isobe Asaichi       | Intendant (dism.)   | Yamaguchi        | Executed | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 村中孝次  | Muranaka Kōji       | Capt. (dism.)       | Hokkaidō         | Executed | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 西田税   | Nishida Mitsugi     | Cav. 2nd Lt. (fmr.) | Tottori          | Executed | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 澁川善助  | Shibukawa Zensuke   | Cadet (dism.)       | <b>Fukushima</b> | Executed | Home                       |
|                                               | 山本又   | Yamamoto Mata       | 2nd Lt. (reserve)   | Shizuoka         | 10 years | —                          |
| <i>Tried: active-duty officers</i>            |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
| ✓                                             | 安藤輝三  | Andō Teruzo         | Captain             | Gifu             | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 香田清貞  | Kōda Kiyosada       | Captain             | Saga             | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 河野壽   | Kōno Hisashi        | Captain             | Nagasaki         | Suicide  | —                          |
|                                               | 野中四郎  | Nonaka Shirō        | Captain             | Okayama          | Suicide  | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 栗原安秀  | Kurihara Yasuhide   | 1st Lt.             | Tokyo            | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 中橋基明  | Nakahashi Motoaki   | 1st Lt.             | Saga             | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 丹生誠忠  | Nibu Seichū         | 1st Lt.             | Kagoshima        | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 坂井直   | Sakai Naoshi        | 1st Lt.             | Mie              | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 竹嵩継夫  | Takeshima Tsuguo    | 1st Lt.             | Saga             | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 田中勝   | Tanaka Masaru       | 1st Lt.             | Yamaguchi        | Executed | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 對馬勝雄  | Tsushima Katsuo     | 1st Lt.             | <b>Aomori</b>    | Executed | Home; 5th Regt, 8th Div.   |
|                                               | 林八郎   | Hayashi Hachirō     | 2nd Lt.             | Tokyo            | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 中島莞爾  | Nakajima Kanji      | 2nd Lt.             | Saga             | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 高橋太郎  | Takahashi Tarō      | 2nd Lt.             | Saitama          | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 安田優   | Yasuda Masaru       | 2nd Lt.             | Kumamoto         | Executed | —                          |
|                                               | 池田俊彦  | Ikedā Toshihiko     | 2nd Lt.             | Kagoshima        | Life     | —                          |
|                                               | 清原康平  | Kiyohara Kōhei      | 2nd Lt.             | Kumamoto         | Life     | —                          |
|                                               | 麦屋清清  | Muguya Kiyozumi     | 2nd Lt.             | Saitama          | Life     | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 鈴木金次郎 | Suzuki Kinjiro      | 2nd Lt.             | Ibaraki          | Life     | —                          |
|                                               | 常盤稔   | Tokiwa Minoru       | 2nd Lt.             | Ōita             | Life     | —                          |
|                                               | 今泉義道  | Imaizumi Yoshimichi | 2nd Lt.             | Kanagawa         | 4 years  | —                          |
| <i>Tried: convicted indirect participants</i> |       |                     |                     |                  |          |                            |
| ✓                                             | 山口一太郎 | Yamaguchi Ichitarō  | Captain             | —                | Life     | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 亀川哲也  | Kamekawa Tetsuya    | — (civilian)        | —                | Life     | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 溝井佐吉  | Mitsui Sakichi      | Lt. Col.            | Fukuoka          | Indirect | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 斎藤劉   | Saitō Ryū           | Maj. Gen. (ret.)    | —                | Indirect | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 末松太平  | Suematsu Tahei      | Captain             | Fukuoka          | Indirect | Posted: 5th Regt, 8th Div. |
| ✓                                             | 菅波三郎  | Suganami Saburō     | Captain             | Miyazaki         | Indirect | Posted: 8th Div.           |
| ✓                                             | 大藏榮一  | Ōkura Eiichi        | Captain             | Ōita             | Indirect | —                          |
|                                               | 鈴木五郎  | Suzuki Gorō         | Intendant           | —                | Indirect | —                          |
|                                               | 井上辰雄  | Inoue Tatsuo        | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | —                          |
|                                               | 新井勲   | Arai Isao           | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | —                          |
|                                               | 志岐孝人  | Shiki Takato        | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | —                          |
| ✓                                             | 志村陸城  | Shimura Rikujō      | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | Posted: 5th Regt, 8th Div. |
|                                               | 塩田淑夫  | Shioda Yoshio       | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | —                          |
|                                               | 柳下良二  | Yanagishita Ryōji   | 1st Lt.             | —                | Indirect | —                          |

Table A.22: Imperial Way Faction Personnel and February 26 Defendants

**Note:** Top panel: the 9 Imperial Way faction members who appear in the right-wing organization source data and were not tried for the February 26 incident. Bottom panels: all 41 persons tried by court-martial for the February 26, 1936 coup attempt (of whom 17 also appear in organization data). Org: ✓ = person confirmed as a named member in the right-wing organization source data. Feb. 26: sentence for those tried; blank for those not tried. “Executed” denotes death by firing squad (July 1936 for active-duty officers; August 1937 for Isobe, Muranaka, Kita, Nishida, Shibukawa). “Life” denotes life imprisonment, later commuted. “Indirect” = convicted as indirect participant (*hobanjō*). “(dism.)” = dismissed; “(fmr.)” = formerly held rank; “(reserve)” = reserve status. NP Link: connection to the northern periphery through home prefecture or military posting. **Bold** home prefectures are within the NP. “—” = no NP connection or information not available. Sources: Shillony (1973), Kitaoka (2021), Kitabatake court records, Kotobank biographical database.

| Org | Name  | Romanized           | Rank          | Home | Division           | NP     |
|-----|-------|---------------------|---------------|------|--------------------|--------|
|     | 草間勇   | Kusama Isamu        | 1st Lt.       | —    | 2nd Div.           | Posted |
|     | 植木勇   | Ueki Isamu          | Captain       | —    | 2nd Div.           | Posted |
|     | 寺尾征太露 | Terao Seitarō       | Capt. (Art.)  | —    | 3rd Div.           | —      |
|     | 黒田武文  | Kuroda Takefumi     | 1st Lt. (Air) | —    | 3rd Div.           | —      |
|     | 片岡俊郎  | Kataoka Toshiro     | 1st Lt.       | —    | 7th Div.           | —      |
|     | 杉野良任  | Sugino Yoshitō      | 1st Lt.       | —    | 5th Regt, 8th Div. | Posted |
|     | 富永良男  | Tominaga Yoshio     | Lt. Col.      | —    | 8th Div.           | Posted |
|     | 遠山弥兵衛 | Tōyama Yahei        | 1st Lt.       | —    | 5th Regt, 8th Div. | Posted |
| ✓   | 小川三郎  | Ogawa Saburō        | Captain       | —    | 11th Div.          | —      |
|     | 江藤五郎  | Etō Gorō            | 1st Lt.       | —    | 11th Div.          | —      |
|     | 三木正明  | Miki Masaaki        | 1st Lt.       | —    | 11th Div.          | —      |
| ✓   | 若松満則  | Wakamatsu Mitsunori | Captain       | —    | 12th Div.          | —      |
|     | 戸次俊雄  | Hetsugi Toshio      | 1st Lt.       | —    | 12th Div.          | —      |
|     | 伊知地進  | Ichiji Susumu       | Captain       | —    | 12th Div.          | —      |
|     | 竹中英雄  | Takenaka Hideo      | 1st Lt.       | —    | 12th Div.          | —      |
|     | 佐々木二郎 | Sasaki Jirō         | Captain       | —    | 19th Div.          | —      |
|     | 朝山小二郎 | Asayama Kojirō      | Capt. (Art.)  | —    | 19th Div.          | —      |
|     | 福永憲   | Fukunaga Ken        | Captain       | —    | 20th Div.          | —      |
|     | 福井寛治  | Fukui Kanji         | 1st Lt.       | —    | 20th Div.          | —      |
|     | 松浦義教  | Matsuura Yoshinori  | 1st Lt.       | —    | Sendai school      | Posted |
|     | 板垣徹   | Itagaki Tetsu       | 1st Lt.       | —    | Toyohashi school   | —      |

Table A.23: February 26 Investigated Suspects (Not Tried)

**Note:** Officers investigated in connection with the February 26, 1936 coup attempt but not brought to trial. Org: ✓ = person confirmed as a named member in the right-wing organization source data. Division assignment reflects the officer's posting at the time of the incident. NP: "Posted" indicates the officer's division was headquartered in the northern periphery (2nd Division: Sendai; 8th Division: Hirosaki; Sendai school). Six of 21 suspects (29%) were posted to NP divisions, with the 8th Division supplying the largest single contingent (3 suspects). Sources: Kitabatake court records.

| Org                      | Name  | Romanized         | Rank          | Home             | NP Link             |
|--------------------------|-------|-------------------|---------------|------------------|---------------------|
| <i>Core leaders</i>      |       |                   |               |                  |                     |
| ✓                        | 東條英機  | Tōjō Hideki       | General       | <b>Iwate</b>     | Home (born Tokyo)   |
| ✓                        | 杉山元   | Sugiyama Hajime   | Field Marshal | Fukuoka          | —                   |
| ✓                        | 小磯國昭  | Koiso Kuniaki     | General       | <b>Yamagata</b>  | Home (born Tochigi) |
| ✓                        | 南次郎   | Minami Jirō       | General       | Ōita             | —                   |
| ✓                        | 武藤章   | Mutō Akira        | Lt. General   | Kumamoto         | —                   |
| ✓                        | 寺内壽一  | Terauchi Hisaichi | Field Marshal | Yamaguchi        | —                   |
| ✓                        | 長勇    | Chō Isamu         | Lt. General   | Fukuoka          | —                   |
| ✓                        | 影佐禎昭  | Kagesa Sadaaki    | Lt. General   | Hiroshima        | —                   |
| ✓                        | 永田鐵山  | Nagata Tetsuzan   | Maj. General  | Nagano           | —                   |
| ✓                        | 橋本欣五郎 | Hashimoto Kingorō | Colonel       | Fukuoka          | —                   |
| ✓                        | 辻政信   | Tsuji Masanobu    | Colonel       | Ishikawa         | —                   |
| <i>Prominent members</i> |       |                   |               |                  |                     |
| ✓                        | 畑俊六   | Hata Shunroku     | Field Marshal | <b>Fukushima</b> | Home (born Tokyo)   |
| ✓                        | 板垣征四郎 | Itagaki Seishirō  | General       | <b>Iwate</b>     | Home                |
| ✓                        | 根本博   | Nemoto Hiroshi    | Lt. General   | <b>Fukushima</b> | Home                |
| ✓                        | 安達二十三 | Adachi Hatazō     | Lt. General   | Ishikawa         | —                   |
| ✓                        | 樋口季一郎 | Higuchi Kiichirō  | Lt. General   | Hyōgo            | —                   |
| ✓                        | 池田純久  | Ikeda Sumihisa    | Lt. General   | Ōita             | —                   |
| ✓                        | 今井武夫  | Imai Takeo        | Maj. General  | Nagano           | —                   |
| ✓                        | 岩畔豪雄  | Iwakuro Hideo     | Maj. General  | Hiroshima        | —                   |
| ✓                        | 河本大作  | Kawamoto Daisaku  | Colonel       | Hyōgo            | —                   |
| ✓                        | 秋草俊   | Akikusa Shun      | Maj. General  | Tochigi          | —                   |
| ✓                        | 富永恭次  | Tominaga Kyōji    | Lt. General   | Nagasaki         | —                   |

Table A.24: Core Control Faction Personnel Appearing in Organization Data

**Note:** The 21 core Control Faction (*Tōseiha*) leaders and prominent members who appear as members in the right-wing organization source data, used in the faction–organization comparison (Section 4.2). Org: ✓ = person confirmed as a named member in the organization source data (all listed here). NP Link: connection to the northern periphery; **bold** home prefectures are within the NP. Several NP-registered members were born elsewhere (noted in parentheses). Sources: Shillony (1973), Kitaoka (2021), Kotobank biographical database.